

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary Urdu

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — fifteen short chapters, with more being written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Urdu is set in Noto Nastaliq Urdu (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Urdu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Urdu and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Urdu reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

Urdu makes several histories visible at once. Its grammar and much of its everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan, closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer on top. Etymology in this book is a memory aid — never a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

Urdu is traditionally printed in the flowing, descending *Nastaliq* style. This edition uses the vendored Noto Nastaliq Urdu family, so the script’s diagonal word shape and joining behaviour reproduce identically in local and published builds. The book keeps romanization beside each new form while the script becomes familiar.

This is a starter edition: fifteen short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Urdu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings and responses	1
1.1 salām	1
1.2 shīm, kāf, re	2
1.3 shukriyā	3
1.4 jī hā	4
1.5 sīn	5
1.6 nahī	6
2 Give your name	9
2.1 merā nām ... hai	9
2.2 alif	10
3 Ask and Answer Names	13
3.1 āp / tum / tū	13
3.2 kyā	15
3.3 lām	16
3.4 āp kā nām kyā hai?	16
3.5 āp se mil kar khushī huī	17
3.6 mīm	19
3.7 Practice	19
4 How Are You?	21
4.1 kaise / kaisī	21
4.2 salām	22
4.3 āp kaise haiñ? / āp kaisī haiñ?	24
4.4 main ... hūñ	25
4.5 kāf	25
4.6 ṭhīk	26

4.7	main̄ ṭhīk hūn̄, shukriyā	27
4.8	nūn	28
4.9	Practice	29
5	Take Leave	31
5.1	khudā	31
5.2	ye	32
5.3	hāfiz	33
5.4	khudā hāfiz	34
5.5	gol he	35
5.6	Practice	36
6	Five Verbs at the Core	39
6.1	honā	39
6.2	nūn ghunna	41
6.3	jānā	42
6.4	ānā	44
6.5	baṛī ye	45
6.6	bolnā	47
6.7	jānnā	48
7	Four Verbs of the Mind	51
7.1	alif madda	51
7.2	sochnā	53
7.3	samajhnā	54
7.4	pe	56
7.5	paṛhnā	58
7.6	likhnā	59
8	Four Verbs Between People	63
8.1	vā ³ o	63
8.2	lenā	65
8.3	pūchhnā	67
8.4	madad karnā	69
8.5	pasand	70
9	People You'd Introduce	73
9.1	bhāī	73
9.2	bahan	75
9.3	dost	76

	9.4	khāndān	78
10		Four Words on the Face	81
	10.1	kān	81
	10.2	nāk	82
	10.3	āṅkh	84
	10.4	muñh	85
11		The Heart	89
	11.1	dil	89
12		Water, Tea, Milk, Bread	93
	12.1	pānī	93
	12.2	chāy	95
	12.3	dūdh	96
	12.4	roṭī	97
13		Four Colors	99
	13.1	lāl	99
	13.2	safed	100
	13.3	kālā	102
	13.4	nīlā	103
14		Four Things You Wear	105
	14.1	qamīz	105
	14.2	jūtā	107
	14.3	ṭopī	108
	14.4	koṭ	110
15		Rain, Sun, Wind, Heat, Cold	113
	15.1	bārish	113
	15.2	dhūp	114
	15.3	hawā	116
	15.4	garmī	117
	15.5	sardī	118
16		Eight Words, Read Rather Than Recognised	121
	16.1	Practice	121

17	The Sentence Learns to End	125
17.1	yih	125
17.2	kām	127
17.3	kahān	128
17.4	yih, kām, kahānī, ham	130
17.5	māñ	131
17.6	yih merī māñ hai	133
17.7	Practice	134
18	The Meeting Comes Off the Page	137
18.1	ām	137
18.2	āsmān	139
18.3	purānā	141
18.4	ām, āsmān, ānā	142
18.5	voh	144
18.6	āp kā nām kyā hai?	145
18.7	Practice	147
	Pronunciation & Script Reference	151
	Glossary	157
	Review Questions	165
	Answer Key	171
	A note on sources	179
	Index	181

Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (3) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 6 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can greet someone in Urdu, respond courteously, and close the exchange naturally. I can also write the three shapes inside shukriyā and the letter sīn from memory.*

Complete UR-C01-nahin, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: greet someone in Urdu, respond courteously, and close the exchange naturally.

1.1 سلام — hello across a family of languages

This is the first Urdu word in this book, and the one you will reach for most. Nothing has to be written today. Look, listen, say it.

Script — notice the direction

Urdu is written **right to left**, traditionally in the flowing Nastaliq style. Begin with four letters:

س s · ل l · ا long ā · م m → **salām**

Letters usually connect inside a word. The tall ا does not connect onward to the final م, creating a visible break. That is enough script for today.

Each of these letters gets a lesson of its own later; their shapes and names here follow Zero Zabar: the Urdu alphabet.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salām is both a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s-l-m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām* and Arabic *salām* are the same historical word; Hebrew *shalom* is a relative.

Your turn — use it

Say **salām** as a friendly short greeting. You will later extend it into the full conventional exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word back.

- A: سلام! — *salām!*
- B: سلام! — *salām!*

Before you move on

Read سلام right to left. Which letter carries the long *ā*? ا. Now cover the romanization and say **salām** once, picturing “peace.”

1.2 ر ک ش — three shapes, then stop

Urdu runs from right to left. Point to the right-hand edge of your page. Today you will meet only three shapes from the spoken word *shukriyā*. The complete joined word waits for the next lesson.

Script — recognize three shapes

Take one shape at a time:

shape	sound	one thing to notice
ش	<i>sh</i>	three dots above
ک	<i>k</i>	a long slash inside the upper shape
ر	<i>r</i>	a simple falling curve

Read them from right to left once: ش · ک · ر — *sh · k · r*.

Writing — trace before you copy

Write these out:

- trace ش once; pause before adding its three dots
- trace ک once; notice the separate slash
- trace ر once; let the curve fall

Tracing is enough. Do not join the shapes or write from memory yet.

Before you move on

Point in this order: *sh, k, r*. Stop after three. The next short lesson adds the final two shapes and only then lets you copy the whole word.

1.3 شکریہ — thank you

Point to ش · ک · ر and say *sh · k · r*. You traced those three shapes already. Keep your pen down while you meet only two more.

Script — add two shapes

Urdu normally omits short-vowel marks. In شکریہ, the visible letters guide you, while the vowels complete the learned word:

ش · ک · ر · ی · ہ → shukriyā

You already know ش *sh*, ک *k*, and ر *r*. Add ی *y/i* and final ہ. That is two new shapes, not five. The final vowel is pronounced long *ā* in this familiar expression.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The central consonants **sh-k-r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude and thanks; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu **shukriyā** reflects the centuries-long Persian-Arabic layer of its vocabulary — and for all that history it is an ordinary, everyday modern Urdu expression.

Your turn

- *salām* — Hello. You can say it; its letters are still ahead of you, so it is printed here the way you say it.

- شکرِیہ — *shukriyā* — Thank you. This one you can already read.

Say the second word slowly once, then at a natural pace. Keep *shuk-ri-yā* as three light beats.

- *Write it:* copy شکرِیہ once while looking at the model; do not write it from memory yet
- *Say it:* **shukriyā** once after the pen stops

Before you move on

Which two shapes did this lesson add? **ی** and final **ہ**. Greet, then thank: **salām** — **shukriyā**. Copying with a model is enough for today.

1.4 ہاں جی — yes, respectfully

Say شکرِیہ once. Point to its first three shapes, then its final two. Your pen can rest; this lesson is for a spoken respectful answer.

The two words

The phrase is written right to left, so جی is the word on the right:

جی *jī* + ہاں *hā* → **jī hā** → yes

In ج, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final sign ں marks a nasal vowel: let some air pass through your nose as you say *ā*. It is not a full English *n* at the end.

That sign has a name — **nūn ghunna** — and you will meet it again.

Grammar Lens: respect inside “yes”

ہاں alone means “yes.” جی adds respect and attentive warmth; it can also be used by itself as a polite response. Learning **jī hā** first gives you a safe answer for many situations.

Your turn

- “Do you understand?” — ہاں۔ جی — *jī hā*.
- “Would you like to continue?” — شکریہ۔ ہاں، جی — Yes, thank you.

Before you move on

Which mark makes the vowel nasal? Final ں. Answer politely: **jī hā**.

1.5 س — three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting

Point at ش, the first shape inside *shukriyā*. Three teeth in a row, a bowl, and three dots floating above.

Script — the shape

س

Three small **teeth** close together — short upward points in a row — and then the line flows straight on into a **bowl** below the baseline.

Remember which way you are working: the first tooth you draw is the **rightmost** one.

No lift anywhere. Teeth and bowl are one continuous movement, and letting the pen stop between them is the commonest way a beginner’s *sīn* comes out looking like two letters.

Its name is **sīn** and it says **s**.

You have seen this shape before. ش *shīn*, from *shukriyā*, is this exact letter wearing three dots above it. Take the dots off and you have س. That is the first pair of many: in Urdu a great deal of the alphabet is one skeleton shared by two or three letters, told apart only by dots.

Your turn

- *Write it:* س — three teeth from the right, flowing into the bowl, one movement
- *Say it:* s

Before you move on

Which tooth comes first? (The **rightmost**.)

1.6 نہیں — no, and later “not”

Say *jī hā, shukriyā* — “yes, thank you.” Now learn the answer that contrasts with *yes*.

Script — recombine known shapes

You have seen ہ, ی, and nasal ں. Add ن *n* at the right:

ں · ہ · ی · ن → **nahī**

Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it. The final ں does not add a strong separate *n* sound.

Grammar Lens: one word, two future jobs

As a complete answer, **nahī** means “no.” Inside a sentence it commonly means “not.” That second job will matter when the track introduces verbs. Today you only need the complete answer. Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened this chapter, this word is inherited Indo-Aryan, part of Urdu’s own core. Hindi says the same spoken word, *nahī*, and writes it in a different script — which you do not need here. The page looks different; the word and its grammar align closely.

Your turn

- *jī hā* — yes. Said, not yet read: its first letter is one you have not met.
- **نہیں** — *nahī* — no. This one you built out of known shapes a moment ago.

Before you move on

What does final **ں** do? It nasalizes the vowel. Answer “no”: **nahī**.

Chapter 2

Give your name

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say my name in Urdu in one sentence, keeping hai at the end where Urdu puts it. I can write alif, and say both directions a Nastaliq word runs in.

One sentence with a slot for your own name: merā nām ... hai, with the copula held to the end of the line.

2.1 میرا ... نام ہے — my name is ...

Greet once, then answer yes and no. The next line gives you one reliable Urdu sentence for your own name.

The exchange

Read the line right to left, but keep its spoken order:

میرا | نام | ... | ہے — merā nām ... hai

- میرا merā = my
- نام nām = name
- your name goes in the open slot
- ہے hai = is

The word **nām** is an old Indo-Aryan relative of Sanskrit *nāman* and distant English *name*. **merā** and **hai** show Urdu’s inherited grammatical core, shared closely with Hindi even though the two languages use different scripts.

Nearly every shape here is one you have already met. میرا opens with م, the letter that begins *salām*, then reuses ی, ر and ا. نام is ن plus that same ا and م. Only the final ے in ہے is new — it is called *barī ye*, the “big ye”, and here the whole word is said *hai*. Learn that vowel with this word and you will meet it again everywhere.

Grammar Lens: the verb waits

Urdu puts **hai** at the end. That is the only sentence-pattern fact to learn now: **my + name + NAME + is**. Keep this one frame; broader word-order and agreement rules can wait.

Your turn

ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — *merā nām Sārā hai*. — My name is Sara.

Replace **Sārā** with your own name. Do not add agreement rules yet; this exact frame is enough for the introduction.

Before you move on

Where does “is” go in this Urdu sentence? At the end. Say the four slots, then say the full sentence with your name.

2.2 ا — one stroke, and a page that runs the other way

Write ا. Three teeth from the right, flowing straight on into the bowl, no lift. That is one letter drawn from memory; here is the easiest one in the alphabet to put beside it.

Script — first, which way the page runs

You met this in your first week, told rather than explained. Here is the whole rule, and it governs every shape from now on.

English marches **left to right**. Urdu marches **right to left**. Your pen starts at the **right edge** of a word and travels **towards the left**, so the letter you meet **first** is the **rightmost** one.

There is a second direction, and it belongs to Urdu in a way it does not belong to Arabic. Urdu is written in a style called **Nastaliq**, and Nastaliq does not sit flat on the line. A word **cascades downward as it moves left**, each letter hanging a little below the one before it, so a word reads like a short diagonal staircase running down to the left.

That is why Urdu looks different from Arabic even where the letters are the same. It is not decoration and it is not optional: it is how Urdu is set.

Script — the letter itself

|

One tall downstroke. Draw it from the top down and lift. Nothing else.

Its name is **alif**, and one thing about it matters more than its shape: **alif does not join to the letter that follows it**. Hold that; the next few lessons will make it pay.

Your turn

- *Write it:* | — one stroke, top to bottom
- *Point to:* at the right edge of an Urdu word, where your pen would begin

Before you move on

How many strokes in alif? (**One.**)

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone’s name with respectful āp, answer with my own, and close the introduction politely. I can write lām and mīm from memory.

A six-line first meeting: greet, ask āp kā nām kyā hai?, answer with your own name, and close with āp se mil kar khushī huī.

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Say **nahī** once, then **merā nām ... hai** with your own name. To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You'll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	<i>āp</i>	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	<i>tum</i>	familiar: friends and peers
تو	<i>tū</i>	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with آ, an alif carrying the long *ā* mark, then پ *p*. تم and تو share ت *t*. In تو, و carries long *ū*.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **āp**
- a friend — **tum**
- the old family — **tum**, **tvam**, **thou**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp.**) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū.**)
Source: *Basic Urdu*: Cultural Notes.

3.2 کیا — what

Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (*āp.*) Now add the question word.

You’ll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — what

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then ا long *ā*. The same ی carried long *ī* in *jī* and *nahī* — words you say but cannot spell yet. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kīm* and the old Indo-European *k/kw-* question family behind English **wh-** words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form you must read here.

Your turn

- Say it: **kyā** — what
- Read it: کیا as **k** + **yā**
- Say it: the family — **kyā**, **what**, **who**, **which**
- Recall: say *salām*, then say *shukriyā*

Before you move on

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in *jī*? (جی.) What does کیا mean? (**What.**)

3.3 ج — alif, and then a bowl under the line

Write *ل*. One stroke, top to bottom.

Script — the shape

ج

Start exactly as you started alif — a tall upright coming down — and then, without lifting, **carry on below the baseline** into a leftward bowl and back up.

One movement, no pen lift. The bowl going **below the line** is the part to get right; it is what tells *lām* apart from alif at a glance.

Its name is **lām** and it says **l**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* *ل*, then ج — the same descent, then the bowl below the line
- *Say it:* **l**

Before you move on

Do you lift the pen between the upright and the bowl? (**No.**)

3.4 ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ — ask a name respectfully

Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — What is your name?

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at **آپ** on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **āp kā nām kyā hai?**
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — **merā nām ... hai**
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end

Before you move on

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.5 ہوتی خوشی کر مل سے آپ — pleased to meet you

Say the opening ladder once: **shukriyā — jī hā — nahī**. Point to the three shapes you traced before the joined thank-you word. Then ask **āp kā nām kyā hai?** and answer **merā nām ... hai**.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ *āp se mil kar khushī huī* **Pleased to meet you.**

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- **āp se** — with you
- **mil kar** — having met
- **khushī huī** — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **āp se | mil kar | khushī huī** in three beats
- the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”
- which word came through Persian — **khushī**

Before you move on

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions.*

3.6 م — a round head, and a tail under the line

Write م. Three teeth, then the bowl, no lift. Now write ل beside it: upright, then the bowl below the line.

Script — the shape

م

A small **round head** sitting on the line, and from it a **tail** running straight down **below** the baseline.

Keep the head small and closed. Plenty of letters dip below the line — you have already written one in lām — but mīm's drop is a **straight tail** hanging off a round head, and that combination is what makes it easy to spot standing alone. Joined into the middle of a word the tail is trimmed away and the head survives.

One movement, no lift.

Its name is **mīm** and it says **m**.

Your turn

- Write it: م — the round head, then the tail below the line
- Say it: m

Before you move on

Is the head open or closed? (**Closed.**)

3.7 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — Salām! B: سلام! — Salām! A: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ —
 Āp kā nām kyā hai? B: ہے۔ سارا نام میرا — Merā nām Sārā

hai. A: آپ سے مل کر مل خوشی ہوئی۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.*

B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line's left.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is with respectful āp, choose kaise or kaisī for the person I am addressing, and reply that I am fine, thank you. I can join four letters into salām, and write kāf and nūn.

The wellbeing exchange run both ways — āp kaise haiñ? and āp kaisī haiñ? — answered with the unchanging main thūk hūñ, shukriyā.

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — “how” follows the addressee

Say **kyā** “what.” Urdu’s next question word begins with the same **k** family, but its ending changes with the person being addressed.

The two words

Urdu	read	use in the respectful question
کیسے	<i>kaise</i>	addressing a man
کیسی	<i>kaisī</i>	addressing a woman

Both begin ک *k* + ی carrying the *ai* sound. At the left edge, کیسے ends in broad ے *e*, while کیسی ends in ی long *ī*. Read the whole word before isolating the final shape.

Grammar Lens: one agreement contrast

English keeps *how* unchanged. Urdu makes this describing form agree with the person addressed: **kaise** for a man, **kaisī** for a woman. Learn only this pair today—not a table of adjective endings. Respectful **āp** itself remains the same for everyone.

Your turn

- *Say it:* addressing a man — **kaise**
- *Say it:* addressing a woman — **kaisī**
- *Point to:* broad final ے versus long-*ī* ی
- *Recall:* say *nahī*

Before you move on

Which form addresses a man? (**Kaise.**) A woman? (**Kaisī.**)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation*.

4.2 Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

Write ں, then ۡ. Four letters are now yours.

Script — the running, falling line

Urdu letters **join**. They run into one another along a single connected line, and because this is Nastaliq that line is also **falling** — each joined letter sits a little lower and further left than the one before it.

Because they join, most letters **change shape** by position. A letter opening a joined run, one buried in the middle, one closing it, and one standing alone can all look different. They are the same letter.

That sounds like four times the work and it is not, because the change is almost always **the same trimming**: the part that identifies the letter stays, and the finishing flourish is cut short so the next letter can start. You saw it already in mīm, where joining costs the tail and keeps the head.

Script — and the letter that refuses

Now the rule that saves the most confusion.

Some letters take the hand of the letter on their right and offer nothing to the left. The run stops dead after them, and the next letter begins as though starting a fresh word.

alif is one of these. So a gap in the middle of an Urdu word is usually not a word break at all — it is a non-joining letter doing exactly what it always does. Without that fact a page of Urdu looks like it has been spaced at random.

What you've built

Four letters, and they spell the word this book opened with:

سلام

From the right: س *s*, ل *l*, ا *ā*, م *m*. Say it: **salām**.

Two things to see. The short vowel between *s* and *l* is **not written** — Urdu prints the long vowels and leaves the short ones to the reader. And the break before the final م is alif refusing to join, exactly as promised.

Your turn

- *Read it:* سلام — name each letter from the right, then say the word
- *Write it:* سلام — let the line fall as it goes, and let it break after alif
- *Say it:* **salām**

Before you move on

What does mīm lose when it joins? (Its **tail**.)

4.3 ہیں؟ کیسی آپ / ہیں؟ کیسے آپ — ask respectfully

Choose respectful **āp**. Then choose **kaise** for a man or **kaisī** for a woman. One final copula completes the question.

The exchange

to a man: آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *āp kaise haiñ?* to a woman: آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — *āp kaisī haiñ?*

The order is **you** + **how** + **are?** Keep **ہیں** *haiñ* final, just as **ہے** *hai* stayed final in the name question. Respectful **āp** takes this plural-shaped copula even when speaking to one person.

Grammar Lens: respect does not erase agreement

Both lines are respectful. The choice between **kaise** and **kaisī** tracks the person addressed, not greater or lesser politeness. If you do not know how a person wishes to be addressed, listen for their usage or ask rather than guess; the grammar lesson does not replace social judgment.

Your turn

- *Say it:* to a man — **āp kaise haiñ?**
- *Say it:* to a woman — **āp kaisī haiñ?**
- *Keep:* respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** in both

Before you move on

What stays the same in both lines? (**Āp ... haiñ.**) What changes? (**Kaise / kaisī.**)

Sources: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation and Personal Pronouns* with “To Be”.

4.4 میں ... ہوں — one frame for “I am ...”

Ask **āp kaise haiñ?** You know the respectful “you are” ending **haiñ**. Your answer needs the first-person pair “I ... am.”

You’ll want to know first — the frame

میں ... ہوں — *main ... hūñ* — I am ...

میں *main* means “I.” Final ں marks a nasal ending. ہوں *hūñ* means “am” and carries long *ū* with ھ, followed again by nasal ں. Leave a space for the state word that comes next.

Grammar Lens: the verb closes the frame

Urdu puts the copula at the end:

maiñ + [state] + **hūñ** — I + [state] + am

Learn only this first-person frame. You do not need the full copula chart to answer one wellbeing question. Notice the useful contrast: respectful **āp ... haiñ**, but first-person **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Your turn

- Say it: **maiñ** — I
- Say it: **hūñ** — am
- Frame: **maiñ ... hūñ**, leaving the middle open

Before you move on

Which word opens the answer? (**Maiñ**.) Which copula closes it? (**Hūñ**.)

Source: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”.

4.5 ک — a bowl with a slash laid over it

Write سلام. Four letters, one break.

Script — the shape



Two movements, and exactly **one** lift between them.

1. a **stem** down, flowing right to left through a **flatter bowl** and finishing with a pronounced **hook** — all without lifting
2. lift once, then a **long slash** drawn down from the upper right towards the stem

The slash is not a dot and not decoration; it is part of the letter, and leaving it off writes nothing at all.

Its name is **kāf** and it says **k**.

Worth knowing: **this is the Urdu kāf**. Arabic writes the same sound with a different shape, and if you have seen Arabic you will notice the difference immediately. Urdu keeps the Perso-Arabic alphabet and does not keep every Arabic shape.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ک — stem, bowl and hook in one movement, then lift and lay the slash across
- *Say it:* **k**

Before you move on

Is the slash optional? (**No** — without it the letter is not written.)

4.6 ٹھیک — “fine,” “well,” and “correct”

Open and close the answer frame: **maĩñ ... hūñ**. The middle now gets one high-frequency state word.

You'll want to know first — the word

ٹھیک — *ṭhīk* — fine, well, correct

The first sound is retroflex and aspirated: curl the tongue slightly back for **ٹ** *ṭ*, then release a puff marked by **ھ**. A plain English *t* is a useful first approximation while the contrast settles. **ی** carries long *ī* before final **ک** *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **ٹھیک** and Hindi *ṭhīk* are the same everyday Hindustani word. Their grammar is closely shared; their scripts make different literary histories visible. This Urdu lesson leaves the Hindi side romanized: mixed-language practice may show both scripts only after each form has been learned in its own right.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ṭhīk** — fine, well
- *Feel:* tongue slightly back, then a small puff
- *Connect:* Urdu **ٹھیک** ↔ Hindi *ṭhīk*
- *Recall:* say *āp* / *tum* / *tū*, then say *kyā*

Before you move on

Where will **ṭhīk** go in the frame **maiṅ ... hūṅ**? (In the middle.)
Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

4.7 شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — “I am fine, thank you”

Fill the frame **maiṅ ... hūṅ** with **ṭhīk**, then recall Chapter 1's *shukriyā*.

The exchange

شکریہ۔ ہوں، ٹھیک میں *Main ṭhīk hūn, shukriyā. I am fine, thank you.*

No word is new. The step is assembling the words quickly enough to answer a real person.

Grammar Lens: keep the copula final

The core reply is:

I + fine + am → **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ**

English places “am” after “I”; Urdu closes the clause with **hūñ**.

Shukriyā comes after the completed answer as the courtesy move you already own.

Your turn

- *Build:* **maiñ + ṭhīk + hūñ**
- *Add:* **shukriyā**
- *Say it:* the full reply without translating each word

Before you move on

Which word must close the core answer? (**Hūñ.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Formal Conversation.*

4.8 ن — a deep bowl, and one dot

Write ک. Bowl and hook, lift, slash.

Script — the shape

ن

A **bowl** swept from right to left, dropping well **below the baseline** and rising again — then one lift, and a single **dot** placed near the baseline, inside the curve.

Two parts, one lift. The bowl is deeper and rounder than the flatter one you drew in *kāf*, and the dot sits low rather than floating above.

Its name is **nūn** and it says **n**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ن — the deep bowl, then lift and place the dot low inside it
- *Say it:* n

Before you move on

Which bowl is deeper, *nūn*'s or *kāf*'s? (**nūn**'s.)

4.9 Practice — an Urdu wellbeing exchange

Choose the question ending for the person addressed, then retrieve the complete answer before looking below.

The exchange

A to a man: سلام! آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* A to a

woman: سلام! آپ کیسی ہیں؟ *Salām! Āp kaisī haiñ?* B: ٹھیک میں

شکریہ۔ ہوں، *Main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā.*

The question keeps respectful **āp** and final **haiñ** while **kaise/kaisī** agrees with the addressee. The reply is unchanged for the speaker's gender: **ṭhīk** does not change, and first-person **hūñ** closes the line.

Grammar Lens: separate grammar from guessing

The two question forms are a grammatical contrast, not an instruction to infer someone's identity. In real interaction, follow the person's own language or ask. The stable beginner default is respect: **āp ... haiñ**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the man-addressed exchange
- *Say it:* the woman-addressed exchange
- *Answer:* **maiñ ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā** after either question

Before you move on

Run both question variants once. If the choice stalls, review only **kaise/kaisī**; if the answer order stalls, review only **maiñ ... hūñ**.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can open a short Urdu conversation, ask how the other person is, and close it with khudā hāfiz. I can write choṭī ye and gol he, and name the face gol he wears in each position of a word.

A four-line interaction with a beginning and an end: salām, the wellbeing check, then khudā hāfiz from both voices.

5.1 خد — the first half of an Urdu farewell

Run one known wellbeing exchange. Chapter 5 will add only the move that ends it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

خد — khudā — God

Read from right to left: خ kh + د d + ā long ā. The short u is learned with the word and is normally unwritten. Let **kh** come from farther back than English *h*, but keep the sound relaxed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu borrowed **khudā** from Persian **khodā**, whose older Middle Persian ancestor *xwadāy* meant “lord.” Learn the Urdu sound and script first; the Persian connection then explains why both tracks will

share the phrase's first historical layer.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khudā** — God
- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* Urdu **khudā** ← Persian **khodā**
- *Recall:* say *kaise* / *kaisī*

Before you move on

Which final letter carries long **ā**? (/.). Which short vowel must be remembered with the word? (u.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Greetings and Introductions; Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 ی — one S-curve, no dots

Write ی. Deep bowl, lift, low dot.

Script — the shape

ی

Start at the **upper right** and descend through an **S-shaped curve**, then carry on left around a bowl that drops **below the baseline**, and finish at its rising tip.

One movement. No lift, and no dots at all. Standing alone, ye is one of the few letters in this book with nothing added to it — no dot, no slash — and that emptiness is how you recognise it.

Its name is **ye**, and it does **three** jobs: the consonant **y**, the long vowel **ī**, and a second long vowel **e**. Which one it is comes from the word, not from the shape — there is nothing on the page to tell them apart.

You have met one already: کیا *kyā*, from two chapters back, uses the consonant. The other two are still ahead of you — نیلا *nīlā* uses the long **ī**, لینا *lenā* uses the **e** — and every letter in both is one you can already draw. Three words, one letter, three values, and only having heard them tells you which.

Your turn

- *Write it:* **ح** — the S-curve down, round the bowl, and up at the tip
- *Say it:* **y**, then **ī**, then **e** — one letter, three jobs

Before you move on

Can the shape alone tell you which of its three values it carries?
(No — the word tells you.)

5.3 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Say **khudā** — a word you hold by ear, not yet by eye. Keep it separate while one second word is added.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hāfiz* — guardian, protector

Read **حافظ** from right to left. **ا** carries long **ā**. Final **ظ** is pronounced **z** in this Urdu word. The short **i** is heard in **hāfiz** but is normally not written as a separate letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiz** is an active participle from **ḥ-f-ẓ**, “guard, preserve.” Urdu receives **hāfiz** through its Persian-Arabic literary layer. Keep “guardian” as the useful meaning; the three-consonant root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hāfiz** — guardian, protector
- *Read it:* **حافظ**
- *Connect:* Arabic **ḥ-f-ẓ** — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hāfiz** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.4 حافظ خدا — goodbye

Retrieve **khudā** and **hāfiz** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now use the two known pieces as one parting move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

حافظ خدا — *khudā hāfiz* — goodbye

Urdu keeps a visible space between the two words. Read خدا first, then حافظ, and preserve that space in the complete spelling حافظ خدا. Say the whole expression smoothly.

Grammar Lens — a whole social move

The protective sense is “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb or agreement ending is needed. It is a reliable polite close for the short interaction learned so far.

Script Bridge — shared history, local spacing

Urdu حافظ خدا and Persian خدا حافظ share the same historical pieces. Urdu conventionally keeps the visible space; Persian normally joins them. Mixed practice may compare the two only now that each local phrase is independently readable.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khudā** + **hāfiz**
- *Read it:* spaced Urdu حافظ خدا
- *Use:* say it when the interaction ends

Before you move on

Where is the local writing contrast? (Urdu shows a space; Persian joins its spelling.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

5.5 ھ — the round he, and its four faces

Write ھ. The S-curve that sweeps below the line and hooks up at the tip. Now say *shukriyā* and think about the shape it ends on.

Script — the shape

ھ

Standing on its own it is **one small closed loop** with a short curved tail falling away to the left. Draw the loop clockwise from the top, then let the tail drop. Its name is ھ *gol he* — “round he” — and it says **h**.

You have already met this letter without drawing it: شڪريه *shukriyā* ends on it, and it has been sitting at the end of that word since your first week.

Joining **trims** a letter, you were told. Gol he is where that promise gets tested, because it changes more than any letter you have written. Four positions, four faces:

- **standing alone**, and at the **end** of a word after a non-joining letter: the small loop with its tail
- **opening** a word: the loop stays, the tail is cut short so the next letter can begin
- **in the middle**: the loop splits into **two small loops side by side**, low on the line
- **closing** a joined word: the loop flattens into a single round curl hanging off the letter before it

The middle form is the one to look at twice. It does not resemble the standing loop at all, and a reader who knows only the standing form meets it mid-word and thinks a new letter has arrived. Same letter, doing its middle job.

The letters in this word

Three words, one letter, three positions. Read each from the right, then copy it while the model is still in front of you.

هم

کہانی

کمرہ

کہانی م. ham “we” — gol he **opens** it, tail trimmed, running into م

کہانی kahānī “story” — gol he sits **in the middle**, wearing the two-loop face. کمرہ kamrā “room” — gol he **closes** it, flattened into a round curl hanging off the / in front of it. Three positions, one letter, and every other shape in all three is one you have already drawn.

Your turn

- Write it: ہ standing alone — the loop, then the falling tail
- Write it: هم — and say **ham**
- Read it: کہانی — name its five letters, and say which face its he wears
- Point to: at the gol he that closes شکریہ

Before you move on

Which word have you been saying since chapter one that ends on this letter? (شکریہ.) What sound does gol he carry? (h.)

5.6 Practice — open, check, and close

Retrieve the known expression for the beginning and the new expression for the end. Keep the middle unchanged.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: *Salām! Āp kaise haiñ?* B: *Main thīk hūñ, shukriyā.* A: خدا حافظ — *Khudā hāfiz.* B: خدا حافظ — *Khudā hāfiz.*

Every line is already learned by ear. **Salām** opens; **khudā hāfiz** closes. The same farewell works for both speakers, so this practice adds no gender choice, pronoun, or copula form.

Only the closing line is printed in script for both voices, because it is the only one whose letters you have all been given. Three pieces of the exchange sit inside your ladder right now — حافظ خدا, شکر, سلام — and the two middle lines wait on letters the next three chapters hand you. Nothing in them is new to say, only new to see.

Your turn

- *Choose:* meeting begins → **salām**
- *Choose:* interaction ends → **khudā hāfiz**
- *Run through:* both voices once from the romanization, then read the closing line off the script alone

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson.

Chapter 6

Five Verbs at the Core

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday Urdu verbs by their shared -nā ending, take that ending off to reach the stem, and say what I do in the present with the participle agreeing for gender and the copula agreeing for person. I can write nūn ghunna and baṛī ye, and read maiñ, haiñ, nahīñ and the copula hai off the page.

The fifth verb runs the whole machine at once: strip -nā from all five infinitives, hold the doubled nūn that keeps jānnā apart from jānā, and put the stem into maiñ jāntā/jāntī hūñ.

6.1 ہونا — “to be,” and the ending every Urdu verb wears

You can already close an Urdu sentence with *hūñ* — “am.” It is still spoken rather than written: its last shape is a nūn with no dot, and that letter arrives in the very next lesson. That small word is a fragment of something larger. Here is the whole verb it was broken off.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہونا — *honā* — to be

Read from the right edge:  *h*, then  carrying *o*, then  *n*, then  long *ā*. Every one of those four shapes has already turned up in a word you

have met. There is nothing new to decode here, which is rare, and worth enjoying.

Grammar Lens: the ending that names every verb

honā ends in **-نā**. So does every Urdu verb when you name it. English marks a verb's plain name by putting a word in front — *to be*, *to go*, *to come*. Urdu marks it by putting **-nā** on the end, and never uses a separate word for it. That ending is also a tool. Strip **-nā** off and what remains is the **stem**, the piece everything else in the verb is built on. **honā** minus **-nā** leaves **ho-**. Learn the ending once, and every new verb hands you its own stem for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

honā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. The middle stage of Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **honā**. The root is Indo-European: **bh^huH-*, “grow, become.” English kept it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **honā** — to be
- *Strip:* **honā** minus **-nā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- *Read it:* **نā** from the right edge
- *Connect:* **honā** ← Sanskrit *bhavati* → English **be**
- *Recall:* say *thāk*

Before you move on

Which ending names an Urdu verb? (**-nā**.) What is left of *honā* once you take that ending off? (**Ho-**.) Which English verb grew from the same ancient root? (**Be**.)

Sources: *Basic Urdu*: Personal Pronouns with “To Be”; Wiktionary:

ہونا.

6.2 ن — nūn with the dot taken off

Write ن. The deep bowl, a lift, and one dot placed low inside the curve.

Script — the shape

ن

The **same deep bowl** you drew two chapters ago, swept right to left below the baseline — and then you stop. **No lift. No dot.**

Every other letter so far was identified by what was **added** to it: nūn's dot, kāf's slash, the three teeth of sīn. This one is identified by what was **taken away**, and the taking away is the meaning. Its name is ن *nūn ghunna*, and *ghunna* is the Urdu word for a nasal hum.

Here is the difference it makes. A dotted ن is a full consonant: your tongue touches the roof of your mouth and you say **n**. A dotless ن asks for no consonant at all. It tells you to send the **vowel before it** through your nose and then stop. In *maīn* the tongue never lands.

Two more facts and the letter is yours:

- ن closes a word and appears nowhere else. Inside a word, that same nasal hum is carried by the ordinary dotted ن, which therefore does two jobs depending on where it stands — a real **n** in some words, a hum in others. Only at the end of a word does Urdu bother to spell the difference.
- Because it ends the word, ن has one shape to learn and no joined faces.

The letters in this word

Three words, all of them already in your mouth, none of them readable until now. From the right:

میں

ہیں

نہیں

main “I” — *haiṇ* “are” — *nahīn* “no.”

The one to dwell on is **نہیں**. It is the word you learned for saying no, in the very first handful of words this book gave you, and it is four letters you can now name one by one: **ن، ہ، ی، ں** — with a dotted nūn opening it and a dotless one closing it, doing two entirely different jobs in a single short word.

Your turn

- Write it: **ں** — the deep bowl, and then nothing
- Write it: **یں**, then **ہیں**, then **نہیں**
- Say it: **maiṇ**, letting the vowel hum and keeping your tongue down
- Point to: at the two nūns in **نہیں** and say what each one does
- Read it: **ہیں** — and say why it ends on a hum rather than an n

Before you move on

Write “no.” (**نہیں**.) Write “I.” (**میں**.) Does your tongue touch the roof of your mouth at the end of *maiṇ*? (**No** — the hum goes through the nose.)

6.3 جانا — “to go,” and two agreements in one sentence

Take the ending off **honā** and say the stem aloud. The next verb gives that same ending a second workout.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānā* — to go

From the right edge: **ج** *j*, then **ا** long *ā*, then **ن** *n*, then **ا** long *ā*. The **ج** is the one from **جی** *jī*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **jā-**.

Grammar Lens: the present tense agrees twice

“I go” in Urdu is two words after the pronoun, not one:

main̄ jātā hūñ — **I go** (man speaking) *main̄ jātī hūñ* — **I go** (woman speaking)

The frame is printed the way you say it rather than the way it is spelled. The **t** of *jātā* and the **ū** of *hūñ* both ride letters you have not been given yet, and a line you cannot decode is not reading practice. The first word is the stem **jā-** plus **-tā**. It says *going*, and it agrees with the **gender and number** of the person doing it: **-tā** for one man, **-tī** for one woman, **-te** for more than one man or for a respectful singular. The second word is **hūñ**, which you already own, and it agrees with **person** — who is speaking.

Two agreements, split across two words, in one short clause. English makes one agreement at most, and usually none. Say both Urdu lines and let the difference sit in the ear rather than on paper.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānā continues Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” from the root *yā-*, “travel.” The change from *y-* to *j-* is not a quirk of this word: initial *y-* regularly hardened to *j-* on the road from Sanskrit into the middle stage of Indo-Aryan that Urdu descends from. Meet the law once and it decodes other words later.

English gives nothing here. The *yā-* root travelled north and west into Lithuanian and Slavic rather than into Germanic, so this is a word where Sanskrit is the whole hook and English cannot help.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **jānā** — to go
- *Strip:* **jānā** minus **-nā** leaves **jā-**
- *Say it:* **main̄ jātā hūñ**, then **main̄ jātī hūñ**
- *Choose:* the ending that fits you — **-tā** or **-tī**

Before you move on

Which word in *main jātā hūn* carries gender? (**Jātā** — the one built on the stem.) Which one carries person? (**Hūn**.) And which Sanskrit verb stands behind *jānā*? (*Yā-*, “travel.”)
Source: Wiktionary: **جاء**.

6.4 آ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

Say **jānā**, then its stem **jā-**. The opposite direction is the same verb wearing a prefix.

You’ll want to know first — one word

آ — *ānā* — to come

From the right edge: **آ**, then **ا** *n*, then **ا** long *ā*. That first shape is *alif madd* — alif wearing a small wave — and it is how Urdu writes a long *ā* at the start of a word. It opens *āp* too, which you will be able to spell out once *p* arrives. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **ā-**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ānā continues Sanskrit *āyāti*, and that word is two pieces: *ā-*, “toward,” plus *yā-*, “go.” So the Urdu verb for *coming* is, underneath, the verb for *going* aimed back at the speaker. “Go toward me” is “come.”

You already have the second piece: *yā-* is the same root that hardened into the **j-** of **jānā**. One Sanskrit verb, two Urdu words, and the difference between them is a direction marker.

English does the identical trick with a Latin verb: *venīre* “to come” plus a prefix gives **advent**, **convene**, **intervene**, **prevent**, and **revenue**. Urdu welds its prefix on the front and lets the seam disappear; English keeps the seam visible.

Your turn

- Say it: **ānā** — to come

- *Pair*: **jānā** away, **ānā** toward
- *Split*: ā- “toward” + yā- “go”
- *Read it*: , starting from *alif madd*
- *Recall*: say *khudā*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are hiding inside *ānā*? (*Ā*- “toward” and *yā*- “go.”) Which Urdu verb shares the second piece? (**Jānā**.) And what does the stem become once **-nā** comes off? (*Ā*-.)

Source: Wiktionary: .

6.5 — the big ye, and the end of the sentence

Write , then , then . An S-curve, a loop, a bowl with no dot.

Script — the shape



A **wide, flat sweep**. Start high on the right, drop through a long shallow curve that goes **well below the baseline**, and carry it a long way to the left, finishing **flat** — with no hook, no lift at the tip, and no dots.

Its name is  *barī ye*, “big ye,” and the letter you already know, , is *choṭī ye*, “small ye.” Two names, one family, and one test that separates them at a glance:

-  *choṭī ye* is narrow and **curls back up** at its tip
-  *barī ye* is broad and **runs out flat**

There is a second difference, and it is about where each one lives. Small ye turns up anywhere in a word — opening it, in the middle, closing it. Big ye belongs to the **end of a word** and turns up nowhere else, which means you will never have to work out its middle face. It has none.

Big ye carries a final **e** or **ai** sound.

The letters in this word

Two letters, and the smallest word in Urdu that does real work:

ہے

From the right: ہ, then ے. Say it: **hai** — “is.”

That is the word you have been ending sentences with since you first said your name, four chapters ago. Read it now.

Two more, both already in your ear:

کیسے

میرے

کیسے *kaise* — “how,” with small ye in the middle and big ye at the end, so the pair sit in one word and you can see the difference for yourself. میرے *mere* — “my” before a plural, every letter of it now yours.

What you’ve built

Twelve letters. Now read the first sentence this book ever gave you, whole, with nothing taken on trust:

ہے ... نام میرا

merā nām ... hai — “my name is ...”. Every letter in it is one you can form: ہ، م، ا، ن، ر، ی، م.

Your turn

- Write it: ے — wide, flat, below the line, no hook at the tip
- Write it: ہے — and say **hai**
- Read it: کیسے — and point at the small ye and the big ye in turn
- Write it: ہے ... نام میرا — and say it with your own name in the gap

Before you move on

Which ye curls up at the tip? (Small ye, ی.) Which runs out flat? (Big ye, ے.) Write “is.” (ہے.)

6.6 بولنا — “to speak,” and the two layers of Urdu

Retrieve the opening without looking: **shukriyā — jī hā — nahī**. Air-trace the five shapes of the thank-you word once. Then return to the three verbs whose stems you pulled from the same ending. Here is a fourth, with one new letter.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بولنا — *bolnā* — to speak

From the right edge: ب *b*, then و carrying *o*, then ل *l*, then ن *n*, then / long *ā*. Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **bol-**.

ب is new, and it is worth one careful second. Its body is a single low scoop with **one dot below**. Hold that skeleton in mind: the very next chapter adds *pe*, which is the identical scoop with **three dots below** — the *p* you already say in *āp*. Same skeleton, different dot count, different consonant. Urdu builds much of its alphabet this way, so counting dots is a real reading skill and not a fussy detail.

Grammar Lens: put it in the frame

The stem takes the same two-agreement frame as before:

mainī boltā hūnī — **I speak** (man speaking) *mainī boltī hūnī*
— **I speak** (woman speaking)

Nothing new is being learned there. That is the point of a stem: the machine is already built, and each verb just walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bolnā goes back to Prakrit *bolai*, “speaks” — and then the trail stops. A link onward to Sanskrit *brūte* “speaks” has been proposed, but it is not settled, so treat it as a maybe rather than a fact.

That plainness is the lesson. Urdu’s everyday verbs are inherited Indo-Aryan and often short-rooted like this, while its formal and literary vocabulary was borrowed from Persian and Arabic and tends to be long, elegant, and easy to trace. Beside homely **bolnā** sits Persian-derived *guftagū*, “conversation,” from Persian *guftan*, “to speak.” Both are fully Urdu. One is the floor of the house; the other is the ornament on it — and the flowing *nasta‘līq* hand Urdu is traditionally written in belongs to that same Persian inheritance.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bolnā** — to speak
- *Count:* ب one dot below — and say what the three-dot version will be
- *Say it:* **main boltā hūn**, then **main boltī hūn**
- *Sort:* **bolnā** inherited, **guftagū** borrowed

Before you move on

How many dots does ب carry, and where? (One, below.) How far back can *bolnā* be traced with confidence? (To Prakrit *bolli*, and no further.) Which layer of Urdu does *guftagū* belong to? (The Persian one.)

Sources: *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet; Wiktionary: بولنا.

6.7 جانا — “to know,” a word English has been carrying all along

Run the four verbs you have — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā* — and pull the stem off each one. The fifth is the closest of them to English.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جانا — *jānnā* — to know

From the right edge: ج j, / long ā, then ج, then ج a second time, then / long ā. Two separate nūns, written out one after the other, and both are pronounced: hold the *n* long, *jān-nā*, the way English does across the seam of *thin · ness*. Strip the final **-nā** and the stem is **jān-**.

That doubling is what keeps **jānnā** “to know” apart from **jānā** “to go.” One letter, and the whole meaning turns.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jānnā continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, from the root *jñā-*, “know.” That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃-*, and English is stuffed with it.

Straight down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth** — literally “un-known.”

Borrowed from Latin (*g*)*nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, and **ignore**, which is “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, and **agnostic**.

So the Urdu verb is not a stranger. It is a first cousin of the plainest word English has for the same idea, and every one of those borrowings is another place to hang it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **jānnā** — to know, holding the long *n*
- *Contrast*: **jānā** to go, **jānnā** to know
- *Say it*: **maiñ jāntā hūñ**, then **maiñ jāntī hūñ**
- *Run through*: all five — *honā*, *jānā*, *ānā*, *bolnā*, *jānnā* — stripping each stem
- *Connect*: **jānnā** ← *jñā-* → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**
- *Recall*: say *hāfiz*, then say *honā*

Before you move on

What single written difference separates *jānā* from *jānnā*? (A second ج, held long in speech.) Which two words in *maiñ jāntī hūñ* agree, and with what? (**Jāntī** with gender, **hūñ** with person.) And which English verb is the same word as *jānnā*? (**Know**.)
Source: Wiktionary: جَانَا.

Chapter 7

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (2) 🖐 Hands-free start: none of the 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Urdu, take the -nā off each verb to reach its stem, and read the two-eyed he that turns a plain consonant into an aspirated one. I can write alif madda and pe, and say which spelling a long ā takes at the start of a word and which inside it.

The fourth verb arrives with no new letters at all: read لکھنا straight off, then run all four stems through main ...tā/tī hūn and sort the chapter's inherited verbs from the borrowed words for pen, book and script.

7.1 ٱ — alif, with a wave on its head

Write ٱ. One tall downstroke, top to bottom, and it refuses to join to whatever comes after it.

Script — the shape

ٱ

The tall stroke you already know, and then **one small wave laid across the top of it**, drawn left to right like a shallow lazy S. Two movements: the downstroke, a lift, the wave.

Its name is ٱ *alif madda* — *madda* means “an extension” — and it says a long ā.

Now the reason it exists, which is the useful part.

Plain *l* does two different jobs. At the **start** of a word it is a carrier: a place for a short vowel to sit, with the vowel itself left off the page. Inside a word it is the long *ā* you have been reading in *kām*, *nām*, *salām*.

So what does a writer do when a word **starts** with a long *ā*? Both jobs want the same stroke, and the answer used to be to write alif twice — carrier plus vowel — which is awkward to write and worse to read. The wave is the shorthand that replaced it. *ā* at the front of a word means: this begins on a long *ā*.

That gives you a rule you can apply on sight. Long *ā* at the start of a word is written *ā*; the same long *ā* in the middle of a word is written plain *l*. One sound, two spellings, decided by position.

The letters in this word

Two words, every letter already yours. Copy each with the model in view.

آنا

آسان

آنا *ānā* “to come” — a word you can now write rather than take on trust.
آسان *āsān* “easy” — look closely: *ā* at the front, plain *l* in the middle, one long vowel spelled two ways inside a single word.

Your turn

- *Write it:* *ā* — the downstroke, lift, then the wave across its head
- *Write it:* آنا, then آسان
- *Point to:* at both alifs in آسان and say which is which
- *Say it:* *ānā*, and name the two movements that make *ā*

Before you move on

How many movements make *ā*? (**Two** — stroke, then wave.) Which verb can you now write? (آنا.) Which of آسان’s two alifs carries the

wave? (The first.)

7.2 سوچنا — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

Say **jānnā** — the one with the doubled *n*, the one that turned out to be English **know**. Knowing is where the mind arrives. Here is the verb for the work it does on the way.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سوچنا — *sochnā* — to think

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **soch-**. That stem is also a noun: سوچ *soch*, “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “a worry.” Both meanings matter; the history explains them.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: س *s*, then و carrying *o*, then چ *ch*, then ن *n*, then ا long *ā*.

چ is new, and you own the trick already. It is the body of *jīm*, the *j* you say in *jī* and *jānā*, carrying **three dots below** instead of one. Second time this has happened: *be* has one dot below the low scoop, *pe* has three. Counting dots stays a reading skill — one you are given by ear here, a lesson before the shapes arrive.

Grammar Lens: nothing new to run it

maiñ sochtā hūñ — **I think** (man speaking) *maiñ sochtī hūñ* — **I think** (woman speaking)

The participle takes gender, هون *hūñ* takes person. The machine is built; every new verb walks into it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sochnā comes through Prakrit *soccadi* from Sanskrit *śocati* — “burns; grieves; mourns” — on the root *śuc-*. The sense cooled by stages: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain

think. Urdu’s everyday word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that went quiet, which is why **soch** is still a thought *and* a worry. State the limit plainly: *śuc-* has **no secure English cousin**. Inventing one would be worse than admitting it.

What is worth noticing sits inside Urdu. Beside inherited **soch**, Urdu keeps Arabic *fikr*, “thought, reflection,” on the root *f-k-r* — and *fikr* also means **worry**: *koī fikr nahīn*, “no worries.” Two words, two unrelated languages, opposite sides of Urdu’s vocabulary, each sliding from thinking to fretting on its own.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **sochnā** — to think; then the stem **soch-**
- *Count*: *jīm* one dot below, **چ** three dots below
- *Say it*: **maiñ sochtā hūñ**, then **maiñ sochtī hūñ**
- *Run through*: **bolnā**, **jānnā**, **sochnā** — speak, know, think
- *Say it*: both meanings of the noun **soch** — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

How many dots does **چ** carry, and where? (Three, below.) What did *śocatī* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Is there an English cousin of *śuc-*? (**No.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: **سوچنا**; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.3 **سمجھنا** — “to understand,” which is a way of waking up

You can think — *sochnā*, three dots under its *che*. You can know — *jānnā*. Between brooding and knowing sits the moment a thing clicks, and Urdu has a verb for exactly that.

You’ll want to know first — one word

سمجھنا — *samajhnā* — to understand

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **samajh-**. The stem is a noun too:  *samajh*, “**understanding, sense.**”

The letters in this word

From the right edge:  *s*,  *m*,  *j*, then  *h*, then  *n*, then  long *ā*.

 is *do-chashmī* *he*, “**two-eyed he**,” named for its two loops. It is not a consonant you pronounce. Its whole job is to grab the letter before it and add a puff of breath:  *j* plus  gives  *jh*.

You have used it once already. In *ṭhīk*, the retroflex *ṭe* takes this same  — retroflex *ṭ*, then the breath. One letter, one job.

Keep it apart from  *gol* *he*, “round *he*,” which **is** a real *h* and which you write in *hūñ* and *honā*. Round  speaks; two-eyed  only breathes on its right-hand neighbour.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

main samajhtā hūñ — **I understand** (man speaking) *main samajhtī hūñ* — **I understand** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

samajhnā comes through Prakrit *saṃbujjhadi* from Sanskrit *sambudhyate*: **sam-**, “fully, together,” plus **budh-**, “**to wake; to become aware.**” To understand something is to come awake to it. That root has a famous derivative. **Buddha** is *buddha*, “**the woken one**” — the same *budh-*, as are *bodhi*, the awakening, and *buddhi*, “intellect.” English borrowed all three without noticing they were relatives of anything.

One stage back the root is Indo-European **b^hewd^h-*, “be awake, be aware.” Its English descendants are quieter: **bode** and **forebode**, about being warned, and **forbid** — Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to command,” a word for making someone aware of your will. So Urdu’s plainest way of saying *I get it* and the Buddha’s title are one word.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **samajhnā** — to understand; then the stem **samajh-**
- *Say it*: **ṭhīk**, then **samajhnā** — hear the same  breath in both

- *Contrast*: **ه** speaks in *hūñ*; **ہ** only aspirates in *samajh-*
- *Say it*: **maiñ sochtā hūñ**, then **maiñ samajhtā hūñ** — I think, I understand
- *Connect*: **samajhnā** ← *budh-* → **Buddha**, “the woken one”

Before you move on

What does **ہ** do, and does it sound by itself? (It aspirates the letter before it; **no**.) What did *budh-* mean, and which famous title is built on it? (**To wake**; **Buddha**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **سمجھنا**; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.4 **پ** — three dots under a boat

Write **آنا** and **آسان**, and say which alif wears the wave.

Script — the shape

پ

A **shallow open curve** lying along the baseline, like a small flat-bottomed boat — and then a lift, and **three dots placed underneath it**, arranged as a triangle with its point downward.

Two parts, one lift. Its name is **پ** *pe* and it says **p**.

The shapes it wears by position follow the pattern you have already seen twice:

- **standing alone** and **closing** a joined word: the full boat, dots beneath
- **opening** a word and **in the middle**: the boat shrinks to a small tooth — a short upward point on the line — with the three dots still beneath it

Note what survives the shrinking. The curve goes; **the three dots stay**. On a page of Nastaliq you find *pe* by counting dots below the line, not by looking for a boat.

That triangle of dots is worth one sentence of history. Arabic has no **p**, so the Arabic alphabet has no letter for it. Persian needed one, invented

it by taking the shape that carries a **single** dot below and giving it **three**, and Urdu inherited the invention along with the script. The same trick made letters for **ch**, **zh** and **g**. So the dots under pe are a record of a borrowed alphabet being altered to fit a language it was not built for — which every language that took this alphabet has done, Urdu among them. Sindhi went furthest of Urdu’s neighbours, and carries around fifty letters to Urdu’s thirty-nine.

The letters in this word

Three words, pe in three different places, and no letter in any of them that is not already yours. Copy each with the model in view.

آپ

پیر

اپنا

آپ *āp* — the respectful “you,” and the word this book has addressed you with from the beginning. Pe **closes** it, wearing the full boat, because alif madda hands nothing to the left.

پیر *pair* “foot” — pe **opens** it, shrunk to a tooth with its three dots still underneath.

اپنا *apnā* “one’s own” — pe sits **in the middle**, the same tooth, hemmed in on both sides.

Your turn

- *Write it:* پ — the boat, then a lift, then three dots beneath
- *Write it:* آپ, then پیر, then اپنا
- *Point to:* at the pe in پیر and the pe in آپ, and say what changed
- *Say it:* āp, and say who you would use it with rather than *tum*

Before you move on

How many dots does pe carry, and where? (**Three, underneath.**)
Why did Persian have to invent this letter? (**Arabic has no p.**)

Write “you.” (آپ)

7.5 پڑھنا — “to read,” and “to study,” and “to recite”

Say *samajhnā*, strip its *-nā*, and hear the breath the two-eyed *ھ* puts into the stem. This verb uses that letter and one more.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پڑھنا — *parhnā* — to read

It is also the ordinary word for “to study”: the noun *parhāī* is “studies, schooling.” Urdu does not keep reading and studying in separate boxes. Strip the *-nā* and the stem is *parh-*.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ *p*, then ڑ, then ھ, then ن *n*, then *ā* long *ā*.

Two are yours: پ, the low scoop with **three dots below**, from آپ *āp*; and ھ, the two-eyed *he* from *samajhnā* — ڑ plus ھ gives *ṛh*.

ش is new, and built from two things you have met. Its body is ر *r*, from شکریہ *shukriyā*. On top sits the very mark that *ṭe* carries in *ṭhik*: Urdu’s retroflex sign, meaning *curl the tongue back*. *Ṭe* is a curled *t*; ڑ is a curled *r*, flicked rather than rolled. You meet the mark here, on the letter that is yours today, and meet its other bearer by ear until the shape is handed to you.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

main parhtā hūn — **I read** (man speaking) *main parhtī hūn* — **I read** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parhnā comes from Prakrit *padhāi*, from Sanskrit *paṭh-*, “to recite; to read aloud.” Its *ṭh* softened into the flapped *ṛh* you have just

learned, and the meaning widened from reciting to reading to studying. Be honest about the far end: **paṭh-** has **no secure Indo-European ancestry**. There is no English cousin, and the trail stops inside India. The near end is better. The oldest sense — *speaking a text you hold in memory* — is everyday, not a fossil. To perform the Muslim ritual prayer is *namāz paṛhnā*, literally “to **read** the prayer,” and nobody performing it holds a book. You already met the word for someone who does that with the whole Quran: a *hāfiz*, on the Arabic root *h-f-ẓ*, “to guard, to preserve.” Guarding a text and reciting it are two halves of one practice — one word borrowed, one inherited.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **paṛhnā** — to read, and to study; then the stem **paṭh-**
- *Count:* ۞ three dots below, and name the word it opens
- *Trace it:* the retroflex mark on ڑ — the same mark ڑ carries
- *Say it:* **maiṅ paṛhtā hūṅ**, then **maiṅ samajhtā hūṅ** — I read, I understand

Before you move on

Name the two everyday meanings of *paṛhnā*. (**To read; to study.**)
 What does the mark on ڑ tell you to do, and which other letter carries it? (**Curl the tongue back; ڑ.**) Does *paṭh-* have an English cousin? (**No.**)
 Sources: Wiktionary: ۞; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

7.6 لکھنا — “to write,” with nothing new left to decode

Three verbs so far: *sochnā*, *samajhnā*, *paṛhnā*. Strip the ending off each and say the three stems. The fourth completes the set, and every letter in it is one you already own.

You'll want to know first — one word

لکھنا — *likhnā* — **to write**

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **likh-**.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, from سلام *salām*; ک *k*, from کیا *kyā*; then ه, the two-eyed *he*, aspirating the ک to give کہ *kh*; then ن *n* and ا long *ā*.
Not one new shape — a whole verb you can read straight off.

Grammar Lens: all four in the frame

main likhtā hūn — **I write** (man speaking) *main likhtī hūn*
— **I write** (woman speaking)

Run the chapter through that frame without changing anything but the stem: *main sochtā hūn*, *main samajhtā hūn*, *main parhtā hūn*, *main likhtā hūn*. One machine, four verbs, and *main ... hūn* holding the ends of every sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

likhnā is Sanskrit *likhati*, “**scratches, scrapes**.” Writing was cutting a mark into a surface. Three other families reached for that picture out of three unrelated roots: Latin *scribere* “to incise,” behind **scribe** and **script**; Greek *gráphein* “to scratch,” behind **graph**; Old English *writan* “to score, to cut,” which is **write**. Four families, each deciding that writing is scratching.

Now the part only Urdu can show you. All four verbs of this chapter are inherited Indo-Aryan, the plain floor of the language — but the **things** writing needs are borrowed to a word: *qalam*, the pen, Arabic from Greek *kálamos*, “a reed”; *kitāb*, the book, from the Arabic root *k-t-b*, “to write”; and *nastaʿlīq*, the Persian name of the flowing hand Urdu is set in. All three are printed the way you say them: each is spelled with letters still ahead of you. The deed is inherited; the equipment came by ship.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **likhnā** — to write; then the stem **likh-**
- *Run through:* all four — *sochnā, samajhnā, paṛhnā, likhnā* — stripping each stem
- *Say it:* the four in the frame — *main sochtā hūn ... main likhtā hūn*
- *Name:* which letter is *che*, which is *ṛe*, and what **h** does to a neighbour
- *Trace it:* *soch-* from grieving, *samajh-* from waking, *paṛh-* from reciting
- *Sort:* **likhnā** inherited; **qalam** and **kitāb** borrowed

Before you move on

Name the four verbs of this chapter and their four stems. What did *likhati* mean before it meant “write”? (**Scratches.**) Which layer of Urdu does *qalam* belong to? (**The borrowed one.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لکھنا; Wiktionary: *qalam*.

Chapter 8

Four Verbs Between People

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask and help in Urdu, build a verb by bolting a borrowed noun onto karnā, and say what I like in the sentence where the thing liked is the subject and I am only the person it happens to. I can write vāʔo, and name both letters that refuse to join to their left.

mujhe parhnā pasand hai — the first Urdu sentence the learner cannot open with mainī. It closes over the chapter's own four verbs by dropping each -nā infinitive into the liked-thing slot, and reuses madad karnā's join in pasand karnā.

8.1 ۞ — a head, a tail, and no hand to the left

Name the letter that takes the hand of what is on its right and offers nothing to the left, so that a gap opens inside a word. (l.)

Script — the shape

۞

A **small round head** at the top, closed like a tiny loop, and then a **tail** that sweeps down and away to the left, dropping below the baseline. One movement, no dots.

Its name is ۞ vāʔo.

Now the part that matters more than the shape. **vāʔo is a non-joiner**, the second one you have met. Like alif, it accepts the letter on its right and

hands nothing to the letter on its left, so the run stops after it and whatever follows begins as if starting fresh. When you see a break inside an Urdu word, you now have two suspects instead of one.

With nothing ever attached on its left, *vāʔo* has no separate middle face to learn. It looks the same wherever it stands; only whether something is joined to its right changes.

And it carries more than one sound. *Vāʔo* does four jobs:

- the consonant **v** or **w**
- the long vowel **ū**
- the long vowel **o**
- and in some Persian borrowings, nothing at all — a letter written and not said

Which one it is comes from the word, not the shape, exactly as with *ye*. Having heard the word is what tells you.

The letters in this word

Three words, three of *vāʔo*'s values. Copy each with the model in front of you.

وکیل

ہوں

کون

وکیل

vakīl “lawyer” — *vāʔo* opens it as a **consonant**, and because it hands nothing leftward, **ک** begins a fresh run right after it. The gap you see inside the word is the letter refusing to join, not a space.

ہوں *hūn* — “I am.” *Vāʔo* is the long **ū** here, and the break after it is the same non-joining behaviour, with **ں** starting clean.

کون

kaun — “who.” *Vāʔo* is the **o** of the diphthong.

One letter, three sounds, in three words you already say.

Your turn

- Write it: و — the closed head, then the tail sweeping down and left
- Write it: وکیل, then ہوں, then کون
- Write it: میں ... ہوں — and say it with something true about yourself
- Point to: at the break after vā°o in ہوں and say why it is there

Before you move on

Write “I am.” (ہوں ... میں) How many sounds can vā°o carry? (Four, counting the silent one.) What tells you which? (Having heard the word.)

8.2 لینا — “to take,” and the letter that will not sit still

Last chapter’s four verbs were about the mind. Say **likhnā**, and name which layer of Urdu *qalam* came from. Now the hands take over: four verbs about what happens between people.

You’ll want to know first — one word

لینا — *lenā* — to take

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **le-**. That is the whole stem: one syllable, no consonant after the vowel. It is the shortest verb you have met, and the etymology says why.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ل *l*, then ی *y*, then ن *n*, then ā long ā.

ی here carries a long e — *le-*, rhyming with English *lay*. That is its **third** job: it supplied a consonantal *y* in کیا *kyā* and stood for long *ī* in *jī*.

A fourth relative is yours too: broad final ڪ, which ends ڪيسے *kaise* and is not the shape that ends ڪیسی *kaisī*. One family of *ye* shapes covering *y*, *ī* and *e*, with the learned word telling you which — the abjad recording enough, not everything.

Grammar Lens: a two-letter stem in the same frame

maiṇ letā hūṇ — **I take** (man speaking) *maiṇ letī hūṇ* — **I take** (woman speaking)

No stem is too small for the machine. **le-** plus **-tā/-tī** plus **hūṇ**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lenā goes back to Sanskrit **labh-**, “**to gain, to obtain.**” Prakrit softened it to *lahai*, then the *-h-* went too and the vowels fused into a single *le*. A three-consonant root worn down to one syllable — the erosion that makes a language’s commonest words its shortest. Prakrit then did something tidy: it levelled *le-* “take” against *de-* “give” so the pair matched. That is why لینا *lenā* and *denā* still rhyme. They are not related; they were made to sound like partners. On the standard comparison, *labh-* matches Greek *lambánein*, “to take, to seize” — which English borrowed repeatedly without noticing. **Syllable** is *syn-* plus *lambánein*, “letters **taken together**”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; a **lemma** is something taken as given, which is why an argument with two of them is a **dilemma**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **lenā** — to take; then the stem, which is just **le-**
- *Name:* ڪ three ways — *y* in *kyā*, *ī* in *jī*, *e* in *lenā*
- *Say it:* **maiṇ letā hūṇ**, then **maiṇ letī hūṇ**
- *Say it:* **maiṇ likhtā hūṇ**, then **maiṇ letā hūṇ** — I write, I take
- *Connect:* **lenā** ← *labh-* → Greek *lambánein* → English **syllable**

Before you move on

What sound does **ی** carry in *lenā*, and name one other value it takes elsewhere. (**Long e**; *y* in *kyā* or *ī* in *jī*.) What did *labh-* mean? (**To gain, to obtain.**) Why do *lenā* and *denā* rhyme? (**Prakrit levelled the pair.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: لینا; *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet.

8.3 پوچھنا — “to ask,” a word Urdu inherited and borrowed at the same time

Say **lenā** and name the sound **ی** carries in it. You also hold کیا *kyā*, “what,” and two whole questions built with it. Here is the verb for the act itself.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پوچھنا — *pūchhnā* — to ask

Strip the **-nā** and the stem is **pūchh-**. It covers both asking a question and asking after someone.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: پ *p*, then و carrying long *ū*, then چ *ch*, then ه, then ن *n*, then | long *ā*.

Every shape is already earned, and two are the dot-counting pair: پ has three dots **below** a low scoop, چ three below the taller *jīm* body. Then ه aspirates the چ into چھ *chh* — its job in *samajhnā* and *parhnā* too.

A written question still ends in the mirrored ؟, closing ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ at the left-hand end of the line.

Grammar Lens: into the frame

main pūchhtā hūn — **I ask** (man speaking) *main pūchhtī hūn* — **I ask** (woman speaking)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pūchhnā is Sanskrit **pr̥cchati**, “asks,” on the Indo-European root **prek-*, “to ask.” Latin took it as *precārī*, “to beg, to pray” — hence English **pray**, **prayer**, and **precarious**, a thing held only as long as someone is willing to be asked. German still asks with it: *fragen*. English’s own inherited cousin, Old English *frīgnan*, died out, so English prays with the related word and asks with an unrelated one. Here is the part that is Urdu’s alone. Persian asks with پرسیدن *porsīdan*, and *porsīdan* is **the same root**, carried west into Iran rather than east into India. Urdu borrowed it back: پرسش *pursish* is “inquiry, asking after someone’s health,” and حال پرسان *pursān-e-ḥāl* is “one who asks how you are.” So *pūchhnā* came down the inherited road, *pursish* came in sideways off a Persian ship, and they are cousins. Urdu is the room where the two roads meet, and the wellbeing question آپ کیسے ہیں؟ *āp kaisē hīn?* is what either of them names.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **pūchhnā** — to ask; then the stem **pūchh-**
- *Count:* three dots below پ, three below چ, then ھ for the breath
- *Say it:* **maiñ pūchhtā hūñ**, then **maiñ pūchhtī hūñ**
- *Say it:* **kyā**, then **āp kaise haiñ** — a word and a question about asking
- *Connect:* **pūchhnā** and Persian **pursish** ← one root → English **pray**

Before you move on

Which English word for praying shares a root with *pūchhnā*, and are Persian *porsīdan* and Urdu *pūchhnā* related? (**Pray; the same root, by two roads.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: پوچھنا; Wiktionary: پرسیدن; Rekhta Dictionary: pursish.

8.4 کرنا مدد — “to help,” and the join that built half of Urdu

Say **pūchhnā** and name the English word for praying that shares its root. Every verb so far was one word ending in **-nā**. This one is two, and only the second half moves.

You’ll want to know first — two words

کرنا مدد — *madad karnā* — to help

مدد *madad* is a **noun**: “**help, aid**.” Alone it does nothing. کرنا *karnā* is the verb “to do,” already readable: ک from *kyā*, ں from *shukriyā*, then نا. Bolt them together: “**to do help**.”

Grammar Lens: only the second half conjugates

main madad kartā hūn — **I help** (man speaking) *main madad kartī hūn* — **I help** (woman speaking)

Madad never changes. It is not a verb and never becomes one; *karnā* carries every ending. This is the **conjunct verb**, the most productive verb-making device Urdu owns: name a noun, add *karnā*, and you have a verb.

You have met *karnā*’s stem before without being told. *āp se mil kar*

khushī hū — the line that closed a first introduction — holds ک *kar* in the middle doing a different job: “**having** met.” One little word, two pieces of machinery.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

مدد is Arabic, on the three-consonant root م-د-د (*m-d-d*), whose verb *madda* means “**to stretch out, to extend**.” Help, in Arabic, is something **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand, though English inherited nothing from *m-d-d* and its own **help** is unrelated Germanic. Better said plainly than dressed up as a cousin.

The root pattern is not new. *hāfiz* sits on *ḥ-f-z*, “to guard, to preserve.” Three consonants carrying a meaning, vowels poured in around them: that is how Arabic builds words, and now you have two. *Madad* travelled the same road as *khudā* — into Persian first, then into Urdu. Here is why the join matters more than the word. A borrowed noun **cannot be conjugated**. With *karnā* it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Urdu took in centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without changing its verb system by one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **madad karnā** — to help; and which half is the noun
- **maiñ madad kartā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartī hūñ**
- two Arabic roots — *ḥ-f-z* to guard, *m-d-d* to extend
- **maiñ pūchhtā hūñ**, then **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** — I ask, I help

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings, and what does *m-d-d* mean underneath? (کرتا; **to stretch out, to extend**.) Why does this join let Urdu borrow so freely? (**The loan stays a noun; native *karnā* carries the grammar.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: مدد; Wiktionary: كرن (Arabic).

8.5 پسند — Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu

Say **maiñ madad kartā hūñ** and name which half takes the endings. Every sentence so far opened with میں *maiñ*, “I.” This one takes that away.

You'll want to know first — *mujhe*, the shape of “to me”

mujhe — to me

Mujhe is what **میں** *main* becomes when the sentence refuses to let you be its subject. It is not “I.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: **م** *m*, then *jīm* carrying *j*, then the two-eyed *he* aspirating it to *jh*, then broad final **ے** for *e* — the shape that ends **کسے** *kaise*. All four already yours.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

mujhe parhnā pasand hai. — I like reading.

Taken apart: **mujhe** + **parhnā** (“reading”) + **pasand** (“pleasing”) + **hai**. Literally: “To me, reading is pleasing.”

parhnā is the **subject**, which is what **ہے** agrees with. No Urdu sentence puts *I* in front of *like*. And any **-nā** infinitive drops into that slot, because an Urdu infinitive doubles as a noun — so every verb of the last three chapters is likeable.

mujhe likhnā pasand hai. — I like writing.

Urdu keeps company with unrelated languages: Spanish *me gusta el libro*, “to me the book pleases”; Italian *mi piace*; Tamil *enakku piḍikkum*, “it catches me”; Bengali *āmār bhālo lāge*, “good sticks to me.” Three families borrowing nothing from each other, each deciding liking happens to you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

پسند is not a verb. It is **Persian**, from **پسنیدن** *pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing” — *pati*-, “towards,” plus *sand*, “to look good.” It arrived as a noun and adjective, and a non-verb cannot carry the liker, so the grammar put that person elsewhere: **mujhe**.

Where *sand* goes next is genuinely **disputed**. One proposal ties it to the root behind Latin *candēre*, “to glow” — English **candid**,

incendiary — and Sanskrit *candra*, “moon,” Urdu’s *chānd*. Lovely, but unsettled.

It came by the Persian road that gave you *khushī*, and sits beside Arabic *مدد* *madad*. *Lenā* and *pūchhnā* are inherited; *madad* and *pasand* are borrowed. Urdu’s hands stayed home; its social words travelled.

کرنہ پسند *pasand karnā*, “to do liking,” reuses *madad karnā*’s join; پسند آنا *pasand ānā* uses آنا *ānā*, “to come” — liking that *comes*.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai**, then its literal sense
- *Swap*: hold **mujhe ... pasand hai**, change the middle — *likhnā* · *sochnā* · *pūchhnā*
- *Say it*: the chapter — *maiñ letā hūñ*, *maiñ pūchhtā hūñ*, *maiñ madad kartā hūñ*, *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*
- *Sort*: *lenā*, *pūchhnā* inherited; *madad*, *pasand* borrowed

Before you move on

In *mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai*, what is the subject, and what part of speech is *pasand*? (*paṛhnā*; a **noun and adjective** from **Persian**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: پسند; Wiktionary: پسندیدن.

Chapter 9

People You’d Introduce

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my brother, sister, friend and family in Urdu, and choose *merā* or *merī* correctly for each noun’s grammatical gender.

Say merā bhāī, merī bahan, merā dost and merā khāndān with merā/merī chosen correctly for each noun, and sort the four into inherited bhāī/bahan against Persian dost/khāndān — the same native-versus-borrowed split Chapter 8’s verbs drew.

9.1 بھائی — “brother,” and the first real English cousin among these nouns

Say **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai**. That closed the verb chapters. This chapter opens a new kind of word: nouns for the people you would actually introduce.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بھائی — *bhāī* — brother

بھائی-میرا — *merā bhāī*. — “[He’s] my brother.”

Urdu, like English, can drop the subject when it is obvious from context — pointing at someone while you say this is enough.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ب *b*, then ه aspirating it to *bh*, then ا long *ā*, then ي, then ی *ī*.

ی is new: **ye with hamza above**. It is a fourth shape in the *ye* family, alongside consonantal *y* in کیا, long *ī* in *jī*, and broad final *e* in کیسے. Its job is narrower than any of those: it marks a glide between two vowels that would otherwise collide — here, between *ā* and *ī*. ه is new too, extending the two-eyed *he* you already know from *jh*, *th*, *rh* and *chh* to a fifth base letter, ب.

Grammar Lens: a noun with a gender

بھائی is grammatically **masculine** — the same class as نام in **merā nām**. That is why **merā** needs no change here. Not every noun agrees this easily; the next lesson breaks the pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bhāī comes from Sanskrit *bhrātr*, “brother,” from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***b^hráHtā**, from Proto-Indo-European ***b^hréh₂tēr**. English **brother** comes from the very same root. Unlike *pasand*’s disputed link to *candēre* two lessons ago, this one is settled: Sanskrit and English are both Indo-European, so **bhāī** and *brother* are real relatives, not two languages landing on the same idea by accident.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **bhāī** — brother; then **merā bhāī**
- *Name*: the fourth *ye* shape — hamza above, between two vowels
- *Connect*: **bhāī** ← *bhrātr* → English **brother**, real cousins
- *Say it*: **mujhe paṛhnā pasand hai** once more, then **merā bhāī**
- *Recall*: say *ānā*, then say *bolnā*

Before you move on

What does بھائی mean, and is بھائی masculine or feminine?
(**Brother; masculine.**) Which English word is its real cousin, not just a resemblance? (**Brother.**) Name the four jobs of the *ye* family now. (**Consonantal y, long ī, final e, and hamza-glide.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: بھائی.

9.2 بہن — “sister,” and the word that makes میرا move

Say **merā bhāī** — my brother, a real cousin of the English word. Here is the other half of the pair, and it changes something you have used unchanged since Chapter 2.

You’ll want to know first — one word

بہن — *bahan* — **sister**

میری بہن — *merī bahan*. — “[She’s] my sister.”

Not میرا بہن. Read on for why.

Grammar Lens: میرا bends to the noun, not to you

بہن is grammatically **feminine**. Urdu’s word for “my” carries that agreement: میرا *merā* before a masculine noun, میری *merī* before a feminine one — regardless of whether the speaker is a man or a woman. It is the noun’s gender that decides, never the speaker’s.

merā bhāī, merī bahan. — my brother, my sister.

نام in Chapter 2’s **merā nām** is masculine, which is why that phrase never had to teach you this rule — one gender, hidden in plain sight, until a feminine noun finally showed up.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bahan continues Sanskrit *bhaginī*, traditionally connected to **bhaj-**, “to share, to portion out” — a sister pictured as a co-heir, sharing the family’s portion. Specialists flag a real problem with the sound history, though: the aspiration in *bhaginī* does not shift the way this derivation needs it to. Hold this one loosely, the way *pasand*’s *candēre* link was held loosely — a plausible story, not a settled one like *bhāī*’s.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bahan** — sister; then **merī bahan**
- *Contrast:* **merā bhāī** — **merī bahan**
- *Say it:* why **merā** changed — the noun’s gender, not the speaker’s
- *Say it:* **bahan** ← *bhaginī* ← *bhaj-*, “to share” — held loosely
- *Recall:* say *jānnā*

Before you move on

Why is it **میری بہن** and not **میرا بہن**? (**بہن** is feminine, and **merā/merī** agrees with the noun’s gender.) What does *bhaj-* mean, and is the connection to *bahan* certain? (“To share”; no, it is debated.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **بہن**.

9.3 دوست — “friend,” and the relationship تم was made for

Back in Chapter 3 you learned three Urdu words for “you” — respectful **āp**, familiar **tum**, intimate **tū** — and were told to use **tum** once a relationship supports familiarity. Here is the relationship that phrase meant.

You’ll want to know first — one word

دوست — *dost* — friend

دوست — میرا — *merā dost*. — “[He’s/She’s] my friend.”

Grammar Lens: a noun that will not pick a gender

bhāī was masculine and needed **merā**. *bahan* was feminine and needed **merī**. دوست breaks the pattern on purpose: it takes **the same form** for a male or a female friend, and **merā dost** works for either. Native Urdu nouns almost always commit to a gender; this Persian loan simply does not carry the machinery that would make it agree.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dost is Persian, inherited from Old Persian **dauštā**, from Proto-Iranian ***jawštā**, from Proto-Indo-European ***ǵews-**, “to taste, to choose, to enjoy.” That root also gave English **choose** and Latin *gustus* — behind English **gusto**. A friend, on this history, is someone **tasted and chosen**, the same picture as *lenā*’s worn-down “take.” Persian’s own word for “ask,” **porsīdan**, turned out to share one root with Urdu’s inherited *pūchhnā*. دوست is not that kind of cousin — Urdu has no inherited word from ***ǵews-** to compare it against — but it is the same general shape: an old Indo-European root, arriving in Urdu by the Persian road alone.

Grammar Lens: where تم (*tum*) actually lives

Chapter 3 taught **āp** / **tum** / **tū** and told you to move to **tum** once familiarity is safe. A دوست is exactly that relationship: someone you have moved off **āp** for. You do not need a new rule — just the word for the person the old rule was describing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dost** — friend; then **merā dost**, for either a man or a woman
- *Contrast:* **merā bhāī**, **merī bahan**, **merā dost** — two that agree, one that does not
- *Connect:* **dost** ← ***ǵews-** → English **choose**, **gusto**
- *Say it:* **āp**, **tum**, **tū** — then name which one fits a دوست

Before you move on

Does دوست change form for a male or female friend? (No — it stays دوست either way.) Which two English words share دوست’s root? (Choose and gusto.) Which of āp / tum / tū fits a دوست? (tum.)

Sources: Wiktionary: دوست.

9.4 خاندان — “family,” the word your three new nouns never needed

Three people-words so far: *bhāī*, *bahan*, *dost* — a specific brother, a specific sister, a specific friend. Not one of them names the group they belong to.

You’ll want to know first — one word

خاندان — *khāndān* — family

میرا خاندان — *merā khāndān*. — “[This is] my family.”

خاندان is grammatically masculine, so *merā* stays unchanged — the same class as *bhāī*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

خاندان is Classical Persian, borrowed into Urdu whole. Unlike *khudā hāfiz*, whose Persian *khudā* and Arabic-rooted *hāfiz* this book could pull apart piece by piece, no source here commits to what خاندان is built from internally — so this one stays a single unanalyzed loan, not a compound to take apart.

Line up this chapter’s four nouns by where they came from. *bhāī* and *bahan* are inherited, straight from Sanskrit, the same road as every kin word before them. *dost* and خاندان are Persian, the same road as خدا and *hāfiz* back in Chapter 5. The people you would point to and name stayed native; the words for choosing them as friends and grouping them as family reached outside the language.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khāndān** — family; then **merā khāndān**
- *Say it:* all four — **bhāī, bahan, dost, khāndān**
- *Sort:* inherited — **bhāī, bahan**; Persian — **dost, khāndān**
- *Choose:* **merā** or **merī** for each of the four

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's nouns are inherited from Sanskrit, and which two are Persian loans? (**bhāī, bahan** inherited; **dost, خاندان Persian.**) Say all four people-words with **merā** or **merī** correctly chosen for each.

Sources: Wiktionary: **خاندان**.

Chapter 10

Four Words on the Face

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my ear, nose, eye and mouth in Urdu, notice that *kān* and *nāk* share the same three letters reversed, and read the *nūn* that marks a nasal vowel instead of a spoken consonant.

Name kān, nāk, āñkh and muñh, explain the plain nūn that nasalizes āñkh and muñh against the dedicated ُ of main and hūn, and count three settled Indo-European cousins found this chapter — nāk/nose, āñkh/eye — against kān’s honest dead end.

10.1 کان — “ear,” where the body words start

Say **merā khāndān** — my family, closing the last chapter. This chapter turns from the people around you to the wellbeing check itself: four words for the body, starting with the one you use to hear the question.

You’ll want to know first — one word

کان — *kān* — ear

کان-میرا — *merā kān*. — “my ear.”

کان is masculine, so **merā** keeps the form you already know from *bhāī* and *khāndān*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

kān continues Sanskrit *karṇa* by way of Prakrit and Apabhramsa *kaṇṇa*. That much is solid. Where *karṇa* itself comes from is not: the trail runs out inside Indo-Aryan, with only a loose, unconfirmed suggestion linking it to Persian  (*kar*), “deaf.” No English cousin, no settled Indo-European root — the same honest dead end *paṛhnā*’s *paṭh*- hit two chapters ago.

Notice the pattern from last chapter still holds:  is inherited, straight from Sanskrit, the same road as *bhāī* and *bahan*. *khāndān*, the word that closed that chapter, was Persian instead — the body’s own words stay native even where their history goes quiet.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kān** — ear; then **merā kān**
- *Say it:* **khāndān**, then **kān** — one word ends, the body words begin
- *Name:* what’s uncertain about *karṇa*’s own origin
- *Recall:* say *sochnā*, then say *samajhnā*, then say *paṛhnā*

Before you move on

Is  masculine or feminine? (**Masculine.**) Does *karṇa* have a secure English cousin? (**No — the origin is unsettled.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: .

10.2 — “nose,” the same three letters as , backwards

Say **merā kān** — my ear, masculine, unchanged **merā**. This word shares every letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

 — *nāk* — **nose**

ناک- میری — *merī nāk*. — “my nose.”

ناک is feminine — **merī**, not **merā**. Grammatical gender does not follow shape or sound; it has to be learned noun by noun.

The letters in this word

ناک is ک ا ن — *n, ā, k*. کان is ن ا ک — *k, ā, n*. The same three letters, in exactly the opposite order. Ear and nose, spelled as mirror images of each other — a coincidence of Urdu’s script, not of its history; the two words are not related.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nāk continues Sauraseni Prakrit *ṇakka*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***náHs**, from Proto-Indo-European ***néh₂s**, “nose.” English **nose** comes from that very root. Where کان’s ancestry ran out unanswered — recall *karṇa*’s own origin was left unsettled last lesson — ناک’s does not: *nāk* and *nose* are genuine cousins, joining *bhāī* and *brother* as this book’s settled Indo-European matches.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nāk** — nose; then **merī nāk**
- *Spell:* **kān** forward, then **nāk** — the same three letters, reversed
- *Connect:* **nāk** ← **néh₂s* → English **nose**, real cousins
- *Contrast:* **merā kān** — **merī nāk**
- *Recall:* say *likhnā*, then say *pūchhnā*

Before you move on

What is the letter relationship between ناک and کان? (**Same three letters, reversed order.**) Is ناک’s English cousin settled or disputed? (**Settled — *nose* shares its root.**) Is ناک masculine or feminine? (**Feminine.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: ناک.

10.3 آنکھ — “eye,” and a fifth letter learns to breathe

Say **merī nāk** — my nose, feminine. The next word on the face is feminine too, and it puts the two-eyed ھ on a letter it has never touched.

You’ll want to know first — one word

آنکھ — āṅkh — eye

آنکھ - میری — merī āṅkh. — “my eye.”

The letters in this word

From the right edge: $\bar{A}$, alif carrying long $\bar{a}$ (the same mark you already read in آپ), then ن, then ک k , then ھ.

ھ extends the two-eyed he to a fifth base letter. It has already aspirated $jīm$ in *samajh-*, $ṭe$ in *ṭhīk*, re in *parh-*, and *che* in *pūchh-*; here it does the same job to ک, giving *kh*.

The ن in this word is not pronounced as its own consonant. It marks the $\bar{A}$ before it as nasal — the vowel said through the nose, with no separate n sound following it. Say **āṅkh** by nasalizing the $\bar{a}$, not by adding a clean n .

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

āṅkh continues Sanskrit *ákṣi*, from Proto-Indo-European ***h₃ek^w-**, “eye, to see.” English **eye** descends from that same root. This chapter has now found two settled Indo-European cousins in a row —

ناک/*nose*, آنکھ/*eye* — after کان’s honest dead end.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **āñkh** — eye; then **merī āñkh**
- *Nasalize:* **ā** through the nose, no separate **n**
- *Count:* five letters now carrying **ñ** — *jīm, ðe, re, che, kāf*
- *Connect:* **āñkh** $\leftarrow$ **h₃ek^w* $\rightarrow$ English **eye**
- *Recall:* say *lenā*

Before you move on

Which letter does  newly pair the two-eyed *he* with, and name two letters it already paired with? (; any two of **jīm**, **te**, **re**, **che**.)

What job does ن do in أنك؟ (Marks the $\bar{a}$ as nasal — it is not its own consonant.) Is ع's English cousin settled? (Yes — *eye*.)

Sources: Wiktionary: آنکھ.

10.4 — “mouth,” and the *ānkh* already used without explaining

Three face words: **kān**, **nāk**, **ānkh** — recall that كان and ناک shared the same three letters, reversed. One more word closes the chapter, and it finally explains something *ānkh* already did.

You'll want to know first — one word

𐌚𐌗𐌊 — *munh* — **mouth** (also: **face**)

میرا منہ — *merā munh.* — “my mouth.”

 is masculine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: م *m*, then ن *n*, then ه *h*, the round *he* you already write in هون and هونا — a real, spoken *h*, not the two-eyed aspirator.

That middle ن *n* does the same job it did in *āṅkh*, unglossed at the time: it marks the vowel before it as nasal, not a separate *n* sound. Say **muṅh** by nasalizing the *u*, with no clean *n* in between.

Keep this apart from مین *main* and هون *hūn*, whose nasal ending is written with a different letter entirely: ڻ, *nūn ghunna*, a dedicated nasalization mark. من and *āṅkh* nasalize with a plain ن *n* doing double duty; مین and هون nasalize with ڻ, a letter built for exactly that job and nothing else. Same sound, two different letters, depending on which word you are in.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

muṅh continues Sanskrit *múkha*, “mouth, face.” One proposal, from the Sanskrit etymologist Manfred Mayrhofer, ties it to a Proto-Indo-European gesture-root **mu-*, “pressed lips” — the same root that would sit behind Greek *mýthos* (“word,” behind English **myth**) and German *Maul*, “mouth.” Mayrhofer himself calls a non-Indo-European origin less likely but does not rule it out. Hold this one the way you held *bahan*’s link to *bhaj-* — a real proposal, not a verdict.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **muṅh** — mouth; then **merā muṅh**
- *Contrast*: plain ن *n* nasalizing in **āṅkh** and **muṅh**; ڻ *nūn ghunna* nasalizing in **main** and **hūn**
- *Say it*: four face words now — **kān**, **nāk**, **āṅkh**, **muṅh**
- *Connect*: **muṅh** possibly ← **mu-* → Greek **mýthos** → English **myth**, held loosely

Before you move on

Which earlier word in this chapter used a plain ن *n* for nasalization the same way من does? (*āṅkh*.) Which letter does مین use instead? (ڻ, *nūn ghunna*.) Is من’s link to Greek *mýthos* certain? (No — a proposal, held loosely.)

Sources: Wiktionary: .

Chapter 11

The Heart

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my heart in Urdu and trace dil to the same Indo-European root as Sanskrit ḥṛdaya and English heart, arriving by the Persian road instead of the Sanskrit one.

*Say merā dil, and trace it through Middle Persian and Proto-Iranian back to the same PIE *kērd- that gives Sanskrit ḥṛdaya, English heart, Latin cor and Greek kardía — dil and ḥṛdaya split at the Indo-Iranian fork, not opposite lineages but the same root by two roads, echoing pūchhnā and porsīdan.*

11.1 دل — “heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word

Recall من: its plain ن marked a nasal vowel, and its possible tie to Greek *mýthos* was held loosely. Recall also *pūchhnā*: one root, two roads into Urdu — inherited *pūchhnā* and borrowed *pursish*, cousins by two different paths. This chapter’s single word runs that same two-roads shape one level deeper, on the body’s most-named part.

You’ll want to know first — one word

دل — *dil* — heart

دل-میرا — *merā dil*. — “my heart.”

دل is masculine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

دل is Persian — borrowed into Urdu from Middle Persian *dil*, by the same road as *khudā* back in Chapter 5. But unlike *khudā*, whose Sanskrit side this book never named, دل has one, and it is worth naming precisely.

Middle Persian *dil* is itself **inherited**, not borrowed, within the Iranian branch of Indo-Iranian: from Proto-Iranian ***jārd**, from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***j^hārd**, from Proto-Indo-European ***kērd-**, “heart.” That is the exact same root behind **Sanskrit** *hṛdaya*, English **heart**, Latin **cor** (behind *courage*, *cordial*), and Greek **kardía** (behind *cardiac*).

So دل and Sanskrit’s word for heart are not opposites, and they did not arrive by accident on the same idea. They are the **same PIE root**, split at the Indo-Iranian fork: one branch went east into Sanskrit and became *hṛdaya*; the other went west into Iranian and became *dil*, then travelled back into Urdu as a loan. Persian and Sanskrit both keep the family’s heart-word — Urdu just happens to have taken the Iranian branch’s copy.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **dil** — heart; then **merā dil**
- *Say it*: the four PIE cousins so far — **bhāī/brother**, **nāk/nose**, **āṅkh/eye**, **dil/heart**
- *Trace it*: **dil** ← Middle Persian ← Proto-Iranian ← PIE ***kērd-** → Sanskrit **hṛdaya**
- *Say it*: one root, two roads — Iranian and Indo-Aryan, the same shape as **pūchhnā/pursish**

Before you move on

Is دل’s resemblance to Sanskrit *hṛdaya* a coincidence, like پسند and *candēre*? (No — **both come from PIE *kērd-***, real cousins.)

Which branch of Indo-Iranian gave Urdu دل, and which gave

Sanskrit **hṛdaya**? (**Iranian; Indo-Aryan.**) Name three other English words from the same root as دل. (**Heart, cardiac, courage** or **cordial.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: دل.

Chapter 12

Water, Tea, Milk, Bread

Modes: ⇨ voice (2) 👁 eyes (2) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, tea, milk and bread in Urdu, say what I like using the frame Chapter 8 built, and sort each word as inherited or Persian.

Say mujhe roṭī pasand hai, reusing Chapter 8’s dative-experiencer frame on a plain noun instead of an infinitive, and sort pānī/dūdh/roṭī as inherited against chāy’s Persian loan — with pānī reusing lenā’s verb frame and dūdh correcting a tempting false cognate with English dough.

12.1 پانی — “water,” and لینا put back to work

Say **merā dil** — my heart, closing the body words, and recall that its PIE root reached Urdu by the Persian road while the same root reached Sanskrit’s *hrdaya* by a different one. This chapter turns to the four things you would actually ask for. لینا, “to take,” from three chapters back, gets its first real use since it was taught.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پانی — *pānī* — **water**

پانی is masculine.

Grammar Lens: naming what you'd take

maiṇ pānī letā hūñ. — I take/get water (man speaking).

maiṇ pānī letī hūñ. — I take/get water (woman speaking).

لینا's stem **le-** slots a noun in front of it the same way any transitive verb does. You already hold the whole verb; پانی is the first noun you have had to put in front of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pānī continues Sanskrit *pānīya*, “water, drink,” built on **pā-**, “to drink,” from Proto-Indo-European ***peh₃-**. English **water** is unrelated — it comes from an entirely different PIE root. But ***peh₃-** itself did reach English, by a different door: Latin *potare*, “to drink,” gave English **potion** and, by way of a sense narrowed to “a poisoned drink,” **poison**. پانی is, underneath, “the drinkable thing” — the same idea English kept for what you drink, not for the substance itself.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **pānī** — water; then **merā pānī**
- *Say it:* **maiṇ pānī letā hūñ**, then **maiṇ pānī letī hūñ**
- *Connect:* **pānī** ← *pā-* → Latin *potare* → English **potion**, **poison** — not **water**
- *Recall:* say *madad karnā*

Before you move on

Is پانی related to English **water**? (**No.**) Name two English words that do share its root. (**Potion** and **poison**.) Say “I take/get water,” once as a man would, once as a woman would.

Sources: Wiktionary: پانی.

12.2 چائے — “tea,” which walked to Urdu rather than sailed

Say **merā pānī** — my water, underneath just “the drinkable thing.” Here is the drink you would politely ask for right after it, and a letter from Chapter 9 makes a second appearance.

You’ll want to know first — one word

چائے — *chāy* — tea

میری چائے — *merī chāy*. — “my tea.”

چائے is feminine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: چ *ch*, already yours from *sochnā* and *samajhnā*; then ^l long *ā*; then ی, hamza-ye, the vowel-glide letter *bhāī* introduced; then ے, broad final *e* from *kaise*. چائے’s ی does the same job it did in *bhāī*: keeping *ā* and the vowel after it from colliding.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

چائے is borrowed from Classical Persian چای (*chāy*), which traces back to Northern Chinese **chá**, carried overland through Central Asia into Persian before Urdu ever had it. That is the same road *khudā* and *dil* travelled in earlier chapters — Persian into Urdu — just with a Chinese starting point this time instead of one further west.

Tea that instead reached Europe by **sea** kept a different form, from southern coastal Chinese, which is why English says **tea** and French says *thé* instead of *chai*. One drink, two words, sorted by whether it travelled by land or by water.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **chāy** — tea; then **merī chāy**
- *Name:* the hamza-ye letter’s two words so far — **bhāī**, **chāy**

- *Say it:* the road — chá ... chāy ... chāy
- *Contrast:* merā pānī — merī chāy
- *Recall:* say *pasand*

Before you move on

Which three languages did چائے pass through, in order? (**Chinese, then Persian, then Urdu.**) Why does English say “tea” instead of “chai”? (**It arrived by sea, carrying a different Chinese form.**) Which earlier Urdu word already used the hamza-ye letter? (*bhāī.*)

Sources: Wiktionary: چائے.

12.3 دودھ — “milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it

Say **merī chāy** — my tea, which walked overland from China through Persian before reaching Urdu. This word is what turns it milky, and it hands the two-eyed د a sixth letter to aspirate.

You’ll want to know first — one word

دودھ — *dūdḥ* — milk

میرا دودھ — *merā dūdḥ*. — “my milk.”

دودھ is masculine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: د *d*, then و carrying long *ū*, then د again, then ه. ه extends the two-eyed *he* to a sixth base letter: it has now aspirated *jīm*, *ṭe*, *ṛe*, *che*, *kāf*, and here it aspirates د, giving *dh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dūdḥ continues Sanskrit *dugdhá*, literally “milked,” from Proto-Indo-European ***d^hewg^h-**, “to be fit, to yield, to produce.” That root also gives Sanskrit **duh-**, “to milk” — the verb sitting

directly under this noun.

Here is the trap. English **dough** looks like the obvious match, and it is **not**: *dough* comes from a completely different PIE root, **d^heigh-*, “to knead, to form” — the root behind the shape of bread, not the substance of milk. The real English cousin of **दूध** is a quieter word: **doughty**, “brave, capable,” from the very same **d^hewg^h-*, “fit for, of use.” A doughty person and milked milk share an ancestor; bread dough does not.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **dūdh** — milk; then **merā dūdh**
- *Count*: six letters now carrying **द** — *jīm, ṭe, ṛe, che, kāf, dāl*
- *Reject*: **दूध** is NOT related to English **dough**
- *Connect*: **दूध** ← **d^hewg^h-* → English **doughty**, the real cousin

Before you move on

Which English word looks like a match for **दूध** but is not one? (**Dough**.) Which English word actually is the cousin? (**Doughty**.) What Sanskrit verb sits directly under **दूध**? (**duh-**, “to milk.”) Sources: Wiktionary: **दूध**; Etymonline: doughty.

12.4 **रोटी** — “bread,” and *pasand* closes the chapter

Three drinks so far: **pānī**, **chāy**, **dūdh** — and recall *dūdh*’s real English cousin was **doughty**, not the tempting **dough**. This chapter’s fourth and final word is the one you would eat, not drink.

You’ll want to know first — one word

रोटी — *roṭī* — bread

मेरी रोटी — *merī roṭī*. — “my bread.”

रोटी is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

roṭī continues Sauraseni Prakrit *roṭṭa-*, from Sanskrit *roṭikā*, “a kind of bread.” That word is built inside Sanskrit itself, on a root meaning “to **strike, to crush**” — the pounding and rolling that turns grain into flatbread. The trail stops there: no proposed

Proto-Indo-European ancestor, no English cousin. **کان** and *paṛhnā* hit the same honest wall earlier in this book. Not every word gets a Greek or Latin relative, and saying so plainly is better than inventing one.

Grammar Lens: *mujhe ... pasand है*, one more time

mujhe roṭī pasand hai. — **I like bread.**

The dative-experiencer frame from Chapter 8 was built for **-nā** infinitives — *paṛhnā*, *likhnā*. It works just as well for a plain noun: whatever pleases you sits in the subject slot, and **है** agrees with it, not with you.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **roṭī** — bread; then **merī roṭī**
- *Say it:* **mujhe roṭī pasand hai**, then swap in **pānī**, then **dūdh**
- *Sort:* inherited — **pānī**, **dūdh**, **roṭī**; Persian — **chāy**
- *Say it:* all four foods with **merā** or **merī** correctly chosen

Before you move on

Does **रोटी** have a secure English cousin? (**No** — **the trail stops at Sanskrit.**) Of this chapter’s four foods, which one is the Persian loan? (*chā²e.*) Say “I like bread” using the frame from Chapter 8.

Sources: Wiktionary: **रोटी**.

Chapter 13

Four Colors

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name red, white, black and blue in Urdu, and tell which colors change their ending for the noun they describe and which never do.

Say all four colors — لال, سفید, کالا, نیلا — sorting the two that agree with the noun’s gender from the two that never change, and trace نیلا’s cousin *nīlī* forward through Persian and Arabic into English aniline.

13.1 لال — “red,” and a word that never changes shape

Recall *rotī* — bread, an honest dead end with no English cousin. This lesson opens a new kind of word: colors, starting with the one you’d use for a ripe tomato or a bride’s dress.

You’ll want to know first — one word

لال — *lāl* — red

merā koṭ lāl hai. — “My coat is red.”

Grammar Lens: a color that never agrees

لال ends in a consonant, not in *l*. That matters: it stays لال whether the thing it describes is masculine or feminine, singular or plural. *merā*

kam̄z lāl hai, merī ṭopī lāl hai — same word, no change. Not every color in this book will be this simple.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

لال is borrowed from Classical Persian لال, “red.” No further ancestor is documented for the Persian word itself — the trail simply stops, the same honest kind of dead end *roṭī*’s Sanskrit root hit last lesson, except this time on the Persian side of the book’s two layers rather than the inherited one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **lāl** — red; then **merā koṭ lāl hai**
- *Note:* لال never changes its ending, unlike the colors still to come
- *Connect:* **lāl** ← Persian, no further root — like *roṭī*’s Sanskrit root, but on the other side of the book’s two layers
- *Recall:* say *bhāī*, then say *bahan*

Before you move on

What does لال mean, and which layer does it belong to — inherited or Persian? (**Red; Persian.**) Does لال change its ending for a feminine noun? (**No — it stays لال.**) Does لال have a documented ancestor before Persian? (**No — an honest dead end.**) Is *khudā hāfiz* written as one word or two in Urdu spelling? (**Two, spaced — unlike Persian’s joined form.**) When you read *ہے ... نام میرا* right to left, does the spoken order of the words change? (**No — the script direction changes, the spoken order does not.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: لال.

13.2 سفید — “white,” and English joins the family this time

Recall لال — red, Persian, and a dead end. This word is also Persian, also ends in a consonant, and also never changes shape.

But its root does not stop where لال's did.

You'll want to know first — one word

سفید — *safed* — **white**

merī ṭopī safed hai. — “My cap is white.”

Like لال, سفید never changes its ending.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

سفید continues Middle Persian *spēt*, from Old Iranian **spaita-*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian **ćwaytás*, from Proto-Indo-European **kweyt-*, “to shine, white.” That is the **exact same root** behind Sanskrit *śvetá*, “white” — so سفید and Sanskrit's word for white split at the Indo-Iranian fork, one road east into Sanskrit, one road west into Iranian and then Urdu, the same shape as دل and *ḥṛdaya* two chapters back.

This time a third road leads somewhere new: that same PIE root, through Proto-Germanic, gives English **white** as well. *pūchhnā* and *porsīdan* were cousins by two roads; سفید, *śvetá*, and **white** are cousins by three.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **safed** — white; then *merī ṭopī safed hai*
- *Contrast:* لال — Persian, dead end; سفید — Persian, and the root keeps going
- *Trace it:* **safed** ← Middle Persian ← PIE **kweyt-* → Sanskrit *śvetá* → English **white**
- *Say it:* one root, three roads this time, not two

Before you move on

What does سفید mean? (**White**.) Name its two settled cousins in other languages. (**Sanskrit śvetá; English white**.) Recall *thīk* and how a short Urdu word once bridged to a Hindi cognate — how

is that bridge different from what سفید just did? (*thik*'s bridge was Urdu-to-Hindi, the same modern language pair; سفید's is a PIE root three languages deep.) How did the earlier take-leave dialogue end? **(With khudā hāfiz, spoken by both voices.)**
 Sources: Wiktionary: سفید, Wiktionary: white.

13.3 ک — “black,” and the first color that agrees

Recall *safed* — white, cousin of Sanskrit *śvetá* and English **white**, three roads from one PIE root. This word is inherited rather than Persian, and it breaks the “never changes” rule the last two colors kept.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ک — *kālā* — **black**

merā koṭ kālā hai. — “My coat is black.”

merī ṭopī kālī hai. — “My cap is black.”

Grammar Lens: a color that agrees like میرا

ک ends in *l* — and a color ending in *l* changes with the noun it describes, exactly the way **merā/merī** changed for gender back in the family chapter. Masculine stays ک; feminine becomes کالی. لال and *safed* never had to make this choice, because neither one ends in *l*. Watch for it again on the last color of this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ک is inherited from Sanskrit *kāla*, “black, dark” — so far, the same kind of story as *bhā* or *āñkh*. But ک's root does not continue into Proto-Indo-European at all. It is usually traced instead to Proto-Dravidian ***kār-**, “black, to be burnt”: Sanskrit itself borrowed this color word from its Dravidian neighbours, long before any of it reached Urdu. Inherited from Sanskrit, yes — but Sanskrit's own source sits outside the Indo-European family this book has been

tracing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kālā** — black, masculine; **kālī** — black, feminine
- *Choose:* **merā koṭ kālā hai** against **merī ṭopī kālī hai**
- *Contrast:* *safed* never changes; **کال** always agrees
- *Name:* **کال**'s root sits outside Indo-European, in Dravidian — unlike every other inherited word so far

Before you move on

What does **کال** mean, and what does it become before a feminine noun? (**Black; kālī.**) Is **کال**'s ultimate root Indo-European? (**No — Proto-Dravidian, borrowed into Sanskrit.**) Which two colors so far never change their ending? (**لال and safed.**) Does *khudā hāfiz* need a verb or an agreement ending to work as a farewell? (**No — speakers use the fixed formula simply as “goodbye,” no conjugation required.**) When choosing **kaise** or **kaisī**, whose gender decides the choice — yours, or the person you're addressing? (**The person you're addressing.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: **کال**.

13.4 نیلا — “blue,” and this book's fourth color closes the set

Recall **کالی/کالا**, the color that agrees, against **لال**, the color that never does. This chapter's last word decides which kind it is, then does something none of the other three managed: it left Urdu again, centuries later, and became an English word.

You'll want to know first — one word

نیلا — *nīlā* — blue

merā koṭ nīlā hai. — “My coat is blue.”

نیلا ends in /, so it agrees exactly like کالا: feminine نیلی.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

نیلا comes from Sanskrit *nīla*, “dark blue.” No further root is documented behind it — an honest dead end backward, unlike کالا’s root, which kept going sideways into Dravidian. But Sanskrit’s related word *nīlī*, “the indigo plant,” did not stop there. It travelled forward: into Persian *nīla*, then Arabic **an-nīl** (“the indigo”), then Portuguese **anil**, and finally into English as **aniline**, the name nineteenth-century chemists gave the dye compound first found in indigo. *safer* reached English through a shared PIE root, inherited by both languages independently. نیلا’s route to English is a completely different shape: one word, borrowed forward through four languages, arriving in English only a couple of centuries ago.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nīlā** — blue, masculine; **nīlī** — blue, feminine
- *Sort:* agrees — کالا, نیلا; never changes — *lāl*, *safer*
- *Trace it:* **nīlā**’s cousin **nīlī** → Persian → Arabic **an-nīl** → Portuguese **anil** → English **aniline**
- *Say it:* all four colors — *lāl*, *safer*, *kālā*, *nīlā* — with *koṭ* or *ṭopī*

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter’s four colors agree with the noun they describe, and which two never change? (**Agree:** کالا, نیلا. **Never change:** لال, *safer*.) What English word ultimately comes from the same root as نیلا’s cousin **nīlī**? (**Aniline**.) Recall the phrase that closed a first introduction with a pleased response — say it now.

(کرم سے آپ **khushī huī**.) Does Urdu spell *khudā hāfiz* joined, the way Persian does, or spaced? (**Spaced**.) Reading ... نام میرا ... right to left changes which direction — the script’s, or the spoken word order’s? (**Only the script’s**.)
Sources: Wiktionary: نیلا, Etymonline: aniline.

Chapter 14

Four Things You Wear

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ◉ eyes (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a shirt, shoe, cap and coat in Urdu, and sort each word by which direction it was borrowed: into Urdu, out of Urdu into English, or straight from English.

Name قمیض, جوتا, ٹوپی and کوٹ, then sort all four by the direction their loan travelled: Persian and Arabic into Urdu, Urdu out into English, or English straight into Urdu — three directions in one small set of words.

14.1 قمیض — “shirt,” and a word that meets its English cousin in a wardrobe

Recall نیلا’s long trip forward into English **aniline**. This lesson opens a new chapter — four things you wear — and its first word makes an even stranger connection than blue did.

You’ll want to know first — one word

قمیض — *qamīz* — shirt

نیلی قمیض میری ہے۔ — *merī qamīz nīlī hai.* — “My shirt is blue.”

قمیض is feminine — that is why نیلا becomes نیلی here.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ق, م, ی, ض.

ق *qāf* is a new letter, said with the back of the tongue drawn further back in the throat than ک *kāf* — in relaxed speech many speakers merge the two, but careful and formal pronunciation keeps them apart. ض *zād* is also new: like *zoʿe*, already known from *hāfiz*, it represents the plain **z** sound in Urdu, even though Arabic once told the two letters apart. Urdu keeps both spellings without keeping the sound distinction Arabic makes.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

قمیض is borrowed from Classical Persian *qamīs*, from Arabic **qamīṣ**, probably from Latin **camisia**, from Proto-West Germanic ***hamiþi**, from Proto-Indo-European ***kam-**, “cover, clothes.” That same Latin **camisia** also gives French **chemise**, borrowed straight into English as **chemise**. Two roads out of one Late Latin word: one east through Arabic and Persian into Urdu, one north through French into English — and both landed, centuries later, meaning a piece of clothing worn on the upper body.

Your turn

- Say it: **qamīz** — shirt; then **merī qamīz nīlī hai**
- Name: ق and ض, the two new letters, and what each is close to — ک and *zoʿe*
- Connect: **qamīz** ← Latin **camisia** → English **chemise**, two roads, one Late Latin source
- Say it: قمیض نیلی — a blue shirt

Before you move on

What does قمیض mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (Shirt; feminine.) Which English word probably shares قمیض’s Latin

source? (**Chemise**.) What does ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ ask, and which word is fixed there regardless of who is asked? (“**What is your name?**”; کا, in this frame.) Name the two new letters in this word and one letter each is close to. (ق, close to ک; ض, close to zoʿe.)

Sources: Wiktionary: قیض, Wiktionary: chemise.

14.2 جوتا — “shoe,” a cousin of yoke, and a cousin of yoga too

Recall *gamāz* and its long-shot cousin English **chemise**. This word’s English cousin is even closer, and its Sanskrit cousin is a word you likely already know.

You’ll want to know first — one word

جوتا — *jūtā* — shoe

ہے۔ کالا جوتا میرا — *merā jūtā kālā hai.* — “My shoe is black.”

جوتا is masculine — that is why کالا stays काल here rather than becoming काली.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: ا, ت, و, ج.

ت *te* is new, and it shares its base shape with *ṭe*, already known from *thik*: the same scoop, but त carries two dots above where *ṭe* carries a small raised loop instead. Two dots make it plain dental *t*; the loop makes it the retroflex *ṭ* the tongue curls back for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jūtā continues Sauraseni Prakrit *jutta*, “joined,” from Sanskrit *yukta*, “joined, yoked,” from Proto-Indo-European ***yewg-**, “to yoke.” That root gives English **yoke** directly, the wooden bar that joins two oxen. It also gives Sanskrit its own word **yoga** — literally “a joining, a

yoking” — the same root, kept inside one language this time rather than split across two. جوتا keeps the oldest, plainest sense: a thing joined onto the foot.

Your turn

- Say it: **jūtā** — shoe; then **merā jūtā kālā hai**
- Contrast: ٲ, two dots, plain *t*; ٲe, raised loop, retroflex ٲ
- Connect: **jūtā** ← *yukta* ← PIE **yewg-* → English **yoke**, and → Sanskrit’s own **yoga**
- Say it: *nālī qamīz* and جوتا کال together

Before you move on

What does جوتا mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Shoe; masculine.**) Name جوتا’s two English-family cousins. (**Yoke, and Sanskrit’s own yoga.**) What marks ٲ apart from the already-known ٲe? (**Two dots above, instead of a raised loop.**) When asking how someone is, does **kaise/kaisī** agree with your own gender or the gender of the person you’re asking? (**The person you’re asking.**) Recall ٲhīk’s Hindi bridge — does it come before or after you can already read the Urdu form yourself? (**After.**) What line closes the take-leave dialogue this book opened early on? (**khudā hāfiz, spoken by both voices.**)
Sources: Wiktionary: جوتا, Wiktionary: yukta.

14.3 ٲوپي — “cap,” a dead end behind it, a loan ahead of it

Recall *jūtā*, cousin of English **yoke** and Sanskrit **yoga**. This word has no such cousin behind it — but it made one of its own, going the other direction.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ٲوپي — ٲopī — **cap, hat**

merī ṭopī safed hai. — “My cap is white.”

ٹوپی is feminine, like روٹی and قامیز.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ٹوپی is inherited from Sauraseni Prakrit *ṭopiā*, “helmet,” related to Sanskrit *ṭopikā*. No further root is documented behind that — another honest dead end, like روٹی and کان.

But ٹوپی did something those two never did: it left Urdu and Hindi and became an English word. **Topee**, first recorded in English between 1825 and 1835, is borrowed directly from Hindi *ṭopī*, “hat” — the lightweight sun hat worn across British India. نیلا’s cousin *nīlī* took four languages and a chemistry lab to become English *aniline*. ٹوپی simply walked straight into English as itself.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ṭopī** — cap; then **merī ṭopī safed hai**
- *Name:* ٹوپی’s own root stops at Prakrit — a dead end, like روٹی
- *Connect:* **ṭopī** → English **topee**, borrowed directly, no intermediate language
- *Say it:* *kālā jūtā* and *safed ṭopī* together
- *Recall:* say *kān*

Before you move on

What does ٹوپی mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Cap/hat; feminine.**) Does ٹوپی have a documented root before Prakrit? (**No — a dead end.**) What English word borrows ٹوپی directly, and roughly when? (**Topee, 1825–35.**) Recall the frame that put *ṭhīk* inside a full sentence — say it now with میں. (ہوں – *ṭhīk* میں) Does *khudā hāfiz* need a conjugated verb to work as a farewell? (**No — it’s used as a fixed formula, no agreement ending required.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: ٹوپي, Dictionary.com: topee.

14.4 کوٹ — “coat,” and every direction a loan can travel

Recall this chapter’s three words: *qamīz*, borrowed from Arabic through Persian; *jūtā*, inherited all the way from Proto-Indo-European; ٹوپي, borrowed *out* of Urdu into English as *topee*. This chapter’s last word takes the shortest road of all.

You’ll want to know first — one word

کوٹ — *koṭ* — coat

ہے۔ نیلا کوٹ میرا — *merā koṭ nīlā hai*. — “My coat is blue.”

کوٹ is masculine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

کوٹ is borrowed directly from English **coat** — a modern loan, one generation old rather than a thousand years. It happens to look

identical to an older, unrelated کوٹ meaning “fort,” inherited from Sanskrit *koṭṭa* — the two are homographs, not cousins, and the spelling gives no warning either way.

This book has named two layers before now: the inherited Indo-Aryan core, and the Persian-Arabic literary layer borrowed centuries ago.

کوٹ is the first clear example of a **third** layer — everyday English loans, arriving through more recent contact. And this chapter has now shown every direction a loanword can travel in one small set of four: Persian and Arabic *into* Urdu (*qamīz*), Urdu straight *out* into English (ٹوپي), and English straight *into* Urdu (کوٹ).

Your turn

- *Say it:* **koṭ** — coat; then **merā koṭ nīlā hai**
- *Name:* three layers now — inherited, Persian-Arabic, and modern English
- *Sort:* *qamīz* in, *ٹوپی* out, *کوٹ* in — three loans, three directions
- *Say it:* all four clothing words — *qamīz*, *jūtā*, *ṭopī*, *koṭ* — each with a color from the earlier chapter

Before you move on

What does *کوٹ* mean, and where does it come from? (**Coat; borrowed directly from English.**) Which of this chapter's four words was borrowed *out of* Urdu rather than into it? (*ٹوپی*, **into English as topee.**) Recall the farewell that closes almost any Urdu conversation — say it now. (*khudā hāfiz.*) What does the standard reply to the wellbeing question say about the speaker? (*تھیک میں* ***thīk***

شکریہ ہوں, — “I am fine, thank you.”)

Sources: Wiktionary: *کوٹ*.

Chapter 15

Rain, Sun, Wind, Heat, Cold

Modes: ⇐ voice (4) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name rain, sunshine, wind, heat and cold in Urdu, and tell which of these words' roots reach back to a documented ancestor and which stop at an honest dead end.

Say all five weather words in one breath and sort each by how far its root reaches: two Persian dead ends, one inherited dead end, one loan of a loan, and گرمی's own root reaching all the way to Greek thermós — the same two-roads shape دل showed on the body's most-named part.

15.1 بارش — “rain,” and why you’d wear the last chapter’s coat

Recall *koṭ*, the modern English loan that closed the last chapter. This chapter gives you a reason to wear it: four words for weather, the small talk that follows almost any “how are you.”

You’ll want to know first — one word

بارش — *bārish* — rain

ہے۔ رہی ہو بارش — *bārish ho rahī hai*. — “It’s raining.”

بارش is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

بارش is borrowed from Classical Persian **bāriš**, itself built from **bār**, “load, downpour,” plus the ending **-eš** that turns a verb or noun stem into an action noun. No further Proto-Indo-European root is documented behind that Persian base — an honest dead end, the same shape as لال’s.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bārish** — rain; then **bārish ho rahī hai**
- *Name:* بارش’s two Persian parts — **bār** plus the **-eš** ending
- *Connect:* بارش’s dead end is the same shape as لال’s — Persian, and no further
- *Say it:* *āj bārish hai, is liye merā koṭ chāhiye.* — “Today there’s rain, so I need my coat.”
- *Recall:* say *āñkh*

Before you move on

What does بارش mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Rain; feminine.**) What two Persian pieces build the word? (**bār, “load/downpour,” plus the -eš ending.**) Recall the three respect levels a single Urdu word for “you” once had to distinguish — name them. (**āp, tum, tū.**) Which letter in **hāfiz** carries the *f* sound? (*fe.*)
Sources: Wiktionary: بارش.

15.2 دھوپ — “sunshine,” rain’s opposite and its etymological twin

Recall *bārish* — rain, Persian, and a dead end. This word means the opposite in the sky, and reaches a dead end from the other side of the book’s two layers.

You'll want to know first — one word

دھوپ — *dhūp* — sunshine

āj dhūp hai. — “There’s sunshine today.”

دھوپ is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

دھوپ is inherited from Ashokan Prakrit ***dhuppā**, “sunshine.” No further root is documented behind that. *bārish* hit its dead end on the Persian side; دھوپ hits the same kind of honest wall on the inherited side — the same shape کان and *roṭī* already showed, not every inherited word traces back to a tidy Indo-European root.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **dhūp** — sunshine; then **āj dhūp hai**
- *Contrast:* *bārish*, Persian dead end; دھوپ, inherited dead end — opposite weather, same kind of etymological wall
- *Name:* two other inherited dead ends already met — کان and *roṭī*
- *Say it:* *āj bārish hai yā dhūp?* — “Is it rain today, or sunshine?”
- *Recall:* read منہ

Before you move on

What does دھوپ mean, and is it masculine or feminine?

(**Sunshine; feminine.**) Is دھوپ’s root documented past Prakrit?

(**No — a dead end.**) Recall whether *khudā hāfiz* is written as one word or two in Urdu spelling. (**Two, spaced, unlike Persian’s**

joined form.) What does آنکھ mean? (**Eye.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: دھوپ.

15.3 ہوا — “wind,” a loan carried twice rather than split once

Recall *dhūp* — sunshine, an inherited dead end. This word moves with the sunshine and the rain both, and its history takes a shape this book has not shown yet: not two roads from one root, but one word handed across two borrowings in a row.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ہوا — *hawā* — air, wind

āj hawā chal rahī hai. — “There’s wind blowing today.”

ہوا is feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ہوا is borrowed from Classical Persian *hawā* — but Persian did not invent it either. Persian itself borrowed the word from Arabic هَوَا *hawā*. *khudā*, back in the take-leave chapter, came into Urdu directly from Persian, inherited within Iranian the whole way. *dil* and *safer* each split from one PIE root into two independent roads, Iranian and Indo-Aryan. ہوا is a different shape again: a single word passed hand to hand, Arabic to Persian, Persian to Urdu — a loan of a loan, not a shared inheritance at all.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hawā** — wind; then **āj hawā chal rahī hai**
- *Name:* three shapes a word’s history can take — one root split two ways (*dil*), a word carried straight through one language (*khudā*), or borrowed twice in a row (ہوا)
- *Say it:* *bārish*, *dhūp*, *aur hawā* — rain, sunshine, and wind
- *Connect:* ہوا ← Persian ← Arabic **hawā**, a loan of a loan
- *Recall:* say *dil*

Before you move on

What does **ہوا** mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Air, wind; feminine.**) How is **ہوا**'s history different from *dil*'s? (**Dil split from one root into two roads; ہوا is one word borrowed twice in a row.**) Name your sister and your friend in Urdu. (*bahan; dost.*)
Sources: Wiktionary: **ہوا**.

15.4 گرمی — “heat,” a secure cousin and a disputed one

Recall **ہوا** — wind, a loan of a loan. This word is Persian too, but its root behaves like *dil*'s and *safed*'s: it keeps going back to a shared PIE root, with a genuine cousin waiting on the other side — though this time the cousin needs a careful claim, not a confident one.

You'll want to know first — one word

گرمی — *garmī* — heat

āj bahut garmī hai. — “It’s very hot today.”

گرمی is feminine.

The letters in this word

From the right edge: **گ, ر, م, ی**.

گ *gāf* is new: it is **ک** *kāf*, already known, with one extra stroke laid across the top — the same dot-count logic that separated *be* from **پ**, except this time the letter gains a stroke rather than a dot.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

گرمی continues Middle Persian *garmīh*, from Proto-Iranian **garmáh*, from Proto-Indo-Iranian **g^harmás*, from Proto-Indo-European **g^{wh}er-*, “warm.” That root securely gives Greek **thermós**, “hot” — the source of English **thermal** and **thermometer**. English **warm** is often mentioned beside it, but dictionaries only call **warm** a “distant doublet” of *thermós*: a proposed relative, not a settled one, with a separate and more likely Germanic root offered as **warm**’s real source.

گرمی’s certain family is Greek’s, not English’s plainest weather word.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **garmī** — heat; then **āj bahut garmī hai**
- *Name:* گ’s relation to ک — one extra stroke, not a dot
- *Sort:* secure cousin — Greek **thermós**; disputed cousin — English **warm**
- *Say it:* *bārish*, *dhūp*, *hawā*, *garmī* — all four weather words so far

Before you move on

What does گرمی mean, and is it masculine or feminine? (**Heat; feminine.**) Which English word is گرمی’s secure cousin, and which is only disputed? (**Secure: thermal/thermometer, via Greek thermós. Disputed: warm.**) Name your family in Urdu. (**khāndān.**) What does منہ mean? (**Mouth.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: گرمی, Wiktionary: warm.

15.5 سردی — “cold,” and one ending that ties this whole book’s weather and warmth together

Recall *garmī* — heat, with a secure cousin in Greek **thermós** and only a disputed one in English **warm**. This chapter’s last

word is its exact opposite, in meaning and in how far its own root travels.

You'll want to know first — one word

سردی — *sardī* — cold

āj bahut sardī hai. — “It’s very cold today.”

سردی is feminine, exactly like *garmī*.

Grammar Lens: one ending, two weather words

garmī and سردی are built the same way: the plain adjective — *garm* “hot,” سرد *sard* “cold” — plus the ending ی that turns it into a noun naming the weather itself. Neither word is a one-off; the ending is a small, reusable tool, the same kind of thing -ن was for verbs many chapters back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

سردی is borrowed from Classical Persian *sardī*, from *sard*, “cold.” No further root is documented for that Persian base — a dead end, the same shape as لال’s and *bārish*’s, and the mirror image of *garmī*, whose root reaches all the way to Greek **thermós**.

Five weather words, every shape this book’s etymology has found: *bārish* and سردی, Persian dead ends; *dhūp*, an inherited dead end; ہوا, a loan of a loan; *garmī*, a root reaching a real if disputed cousin — the same two-roads shape دل showed on the body’s most-named part.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **sardī** — cold; then **āj bahut sardī hai**
- *Contrast:* *garmī*, a root reaching Greek; سردی, a Persian dead end
- *Say it:* all four weather words in one breath — **bārish, dhūp, ہوا, garmī, سردی**
- *Recall:* دل’s two roads from one PIE root, and how *garmī*’s own root follows the same shape

Before you move on

What does سردی mean? (**Cold.**) Does its root reach as far as *garmī*'s? (**No — a Persian dead end.**) Which letter in *bhā̄* marks the glide between two vowels? (**hamza-ye, ye with hamza.**) Which two face words share the same three letters reversed? (کأن and ناک.) What job does plain ن do in *ānkh* and منه? (**Marks the vowel before it as nasal.**) What PIE root ties دل to Sanskrit *hṛdaya*? (***kērd-**, split at the Indo-Iranian fork.) Sources: Wiktionary: سردی.

Chapter 16

Eight Words, Read Rather Than Recognised

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read salam, kya, kan, nak, lal, kala, nila and lena letter by letter from the right rather than from the romanization, and explain why Urdu leaves its short vowels unwritten.

Eight words the book had only ever given by ear, read letter by letter from the right – including kan and nak, the same three letters in different orders, which is the proof that the reader is decoding rather than recognising. Every letter the reading needs was taught back in chapters one to five.

16.1 Practice — eight words you already knew, now read

Write the seven letters this reading needs — ک، م، س، ل، ا، — in a row, right to left, naming each as you go, and let the line fall as it travels.

Script — the words come back

Nothing new is taught here. Every word below was already given to you to say, and every letter in it is one you can now write.

Read each from the right, naming its letters before you say it:

سلام

کیا

کان

ناک

لال

کالا

نیلا

لینا

salām — kyā — kān — nāk — lāl — kālā — nīlā — lenā.

Eight words from seven letters. Two of them are worth a second look:

کان *kān* “ear” and ناک *nāk* “nose” use the **same three letters** in different orders, which is the clearest possible proof that you are reading rather than recognising a picture.

Why it’s said this way

Count the letters in کیا and count the sounds in *kyā*.

Urdu writes its long vowels and leaves the short ones off the page. The reader supplies them. That is why *salām* has a vowel between the s and the l that nothing on the page records.

This has a consequence worth accepting now rather than discovering later: **you cannot reliably sound out an Urdu word you have never heard.** Reading and listening have to grow together here, more tightly than in a language that spells every vowel — which is exactly why this book put every one of these words in your ear, chapters before it asked you to read one.

What you’ve built this chapter

Seven letters you have been carrying since chapter five, and three ideas that outlast them:

- **the page runs right to left**, and in Nastaliq the word also **falls** as it goes, each letter hanging below the last
- **letters join**, changing shape by position — but the change is a **trimming**, and **alif refuses to join leftward**, which is what puts gaps inside a word
- **what is added matters**: nūn’s dot, kāf’s slash, and ye’s bare curve are the identification, not the decoration

Seven of Urdu’s letters. The rest are mostly more of what you just did.

Your turn

- *Read it*: ناک and کان — same three letters, and say which is which
- *Write it*: سلام — and let it break after alif
- *Read it*: لال نیلا کالا — name the letters of each before saying it

Before you move on

Which of your seven letters refuses to join to the left? (l.)

Chapter 17

The Sentence Learns to End

Modes: ⇐ voice (4) 👁 eyes (3) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 3 of 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read yih, kaam, kahan, maan and the copula hai off the page rather than from the romanization, write mera naam ... hai from dictation, and put gol he, bari ye and nun ghunna back to work in words I had only heard.

The copula hai comes off the page, and with it every sentence the reader already knew how to end, including mera naam ... hai, the first sentence the book ever gave them – built from three letters learned eleven chapters earlier and returned to here.

17.1 ٺ — “this,” and the letter you are owed

Read these off the page, naming the letters from the right before you say each word:

کان

ناک

kān — ear. nāk — nose. Seven letters bought you those.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ٺ — yih — this

Point at something within reach and name it:

کان یہ — *yih kān* — “this ear”

ناک یہ — *yih nāk* — “this nose”

Two letters, and you can read the first of them: **ی**, the S-curve with no dots. The second is new to your eye, and it will stay new for two more lessons. Say the word now; you will write it shortly.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ی points at what is **near** you. Urdu keeps a second word for what is **far**, and the two arrived together: both descend from the Old Indo-Aryan demonstratives that Sanskrit wrote as *iyam* and *asau*. English lost most of that system and kept a thinner **this/that**; Urdu kept the pair intact.

There is a gap in what you can do with ی so far, and it is worth naming. *yih kān* is “this ear” — a label, not yet a sentence. To say “**this is** an ear” you need the small word *hai* at the end, which you have been saying since you gave your name. You cannot write *hai* yet, because both of its letters are still missing from your hand.

That is what this chapter buys back.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **yih** — this
- *Say it:* **yih kān**, then **yih nāk**, pointing each time
- *Read it:* کان and ناک, naming their letters from the right
- *Say it:* the near word **yih**, and name what it still needs to become a sentence — *hai*
- *Recall:* say *roṭī*, then read لال, then say *safed*

Before you move on

Say “this ear.” (**yih kān**.) Which of ی’s two letters can you already write? (The first one, **ی**.) What small word would turn *yih kān* into a full sentence? (**hai**.)

Sources: Wiktionary: ی.

17.2 کام — “work,” and a word you can read the moment you meet it

Say the near-pointing word, then point at your own ear and use it. (*yih*; *yih kām*.)

You’ll want to know first — one word

کام — *kām* — work

Now do something you could not do with any word before this one.

Read it off the page. From the right: م, ا, ک.

Every letter in it is already yours, so this word arrives readable on the day you meet it. That is what the seven letters were for.

کام is masculine.

yih kām — “this work” — the near-pointing word is still an ear-word; its second letter reaches your hand next lesson

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

کام is **inherited**, not borrowed: Sanskrit *karman* “act, deed, work” became Prakrit *kamma* and then Urdu *kām*, losing a syllable to a few thousand years of being said out loud.

Then look at what English did with the same word. English did not inherit it — English **borrowed** it, late, out of books, and borrowed it whole: **karma**.

So one Sanskrit word reached two languages by two roads. The road through ordinary Indian speech wore it down to a plain word for the work you have to get done today. The road through scholarship carried it into English untouched and left it meaning cosmic consequence.

Same word. The difference in weight is the difference between being inherited and being borrowed, and you have watched that same fork before, when *pūchhnā* met *pursish*.

A caution worth keeping: Urdu has a **second** *kām*, from Sanskrit *kāma* “desire,” and it is a different word wearing the same clothes. This chapter means the working one.

Your turn

- *Read it:* کام — name the three letters from the right, then say it
- *Say it:* **kām** — work; then **yih kām**
- *Write it:* کام — three letters, right to left, letting the line fall
- *Trace it:* **kām** ← Prakrit *kamma* ← Sanskrit *karman* → borrowed into English as **karma**
- *Recall:* read ٲک, then say *nīlā*, then say *qamīz*

Before you move on

Name کام's three letters from the right. (م، ا، ک.) Say “this work.” (**yih kām.**) Which road shortened the word, the inherited one or the borrowed one? (**The inherited one.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: کام.

17.3 کہاں — “where,” and the family it belongs to

Write یہ and say it. Which face is *gol* he wearing there — the opening one, the middle one, or the closing one? (**Closing.**)

You'll want to know first — one word

کہاں — *kahānī* — **where**

Four letters. Three of them are yours: ک, then ہ wearing its middle face, then ل. The fourth is new, and it carries the nasal hum you can hear at the end of *kahānī* — the same hum that ends *maīnī*, *hūnī* and *nahīnī*. You wrote it back in chapter six: it is *nūn* with the dot taken off.

یہ کہاں؟ — *yih kahānī?* — “this, where?” — pointing and asking at once

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Put the question words you have met beside the new one and read down the right edge:

- کیا — *kyā* — what
- کہاں — *kahāñ* — where
- *kaun* — who
- *kab* — when
- *kaise* — how

Every one of them opens with ک. That shared consonant is not a coincidence and not a tidy invention: it is inherited. All five come from the Old Indo-Aryan interrogative stem *ka-*, and کہاں in particular runs back through Prakrit *kahiñ* to Sanskrit *kasmin*, “in what.”

Now say the English list out loud — *who, what, when, where, how* — and listen for its own shared opening. English marks its questions with **wh**, Latin marks them with **qu** in *quis* and *quid*, and Urdu marks

them with ک. Three marks, one inherited consonant:

Proto-Indo-European ***k^wis**, split three ways by three sound histories.

So a learner meeting کہاں is not memorising an arbitrary shape. They are meeting a relative of the word they already use for the same job.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **kahāñ** — where; then **yih kahāñ?**
- *Say it:* the five k- question words — **kyā, kahāñ, kaun, kab, kaise**
- *Read it:* کیا and کہاں, naming their letters from the right
- *Trace it:* **kahāñ** ← Prakrit *kahiñ* ← Sanskrit *kasmin* ← PIE ***k^wis**
→ English **where**, Latin **quis**
- *Recall:* say *jūtā*

Before you move on

Say “where.” (**kaḥāñ.**) How many of its four letters can you already write? (**Three.**) Name two other members of its k- family. (**kyā, kaun, kab, kaise** — any two.)

Sources: Wiktionary: کہاں.

17.4 Eight letters — read them, hear them, write them back

Say the eight letters you can now write, and say what the newest one does in the middle of a word. (**h**; it splits into **two small loops**.)

The letters in this word

Nothing new here. Ten words, every letter already yours. Read each from the right, naming its letters before you say it.

سلام

کان

ناک

لال

کالا

نیلا

لینا

کام

یہ

ہم

Two of them are new to your eye this chapter: کام *kām* “work” and یہ *yih* “this.” Two more are old friends whose letters you could not have named a chapter ago.

Your turn

Now hide the page. For each word below: look at it, cover it, write it from memory, then uncover and repair whatever came out wrong. Repairing is the part that teaches — do not skip to the next word until you have compared.

- Write it: **ک** — look, cover, write, uncover, repair
- Write it: **کام** — look, cover, write, uncover, repair
- Write it: **کام** — look, cover, write, uncover, repair
- Say it: **kahān**, and name the one letter in it you still cannot form

Your turn — by ear

Now the ear, with the page shut.

- Say it: **yih kām**, **yih nāk**, **yih kām** — pointing each time
- Say it: **kahān** — and the four other k- question words
- Say it: **kām** and English **karma**, and which one was inherited
- Listen: for the nasal hum at the end of *kahān*, and hum it back

Before you move on

How many letters can you write? (**Eight.**) Which word in this lesson still has a letter you cannot form? (**kahān.**) What sound is that letter carrying? (**The nasal hum at the end.**)

17.5 ماں — “mother,” and a sentence you can read whole

Write **ہے** and say it. Then write **ہے ... نام میرا** and say it with your own name in the gap.

You'll want to know first — one word

ماں — *māñ* — **mother**

ماں is feminine, so the possessive takes its feminine form — *merī*, not *merā*, the same choice you already make for *bahan*.

ہے۔ ماں میری یہ — *yih merī māñ hai.* — “This is my mother.”

Read that sentence off the page. Every letter in it is one you can form except the last of ماں, which arrives shortly — and you can hear exactly where it goes, because it is the nasal hum you have been putting on the end of *mañ* and *hūñ* all along.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ماں is **inherited**. It comes down through Prakrit from Sanskrit *mātā*, stem *mātr*, and behind that stands Proto-Indo-European ***méh₂tēr**. The same root gives English **mother**, Latin **mater** (behind *maternal*, *matrix*), Greek **mētēr**, and Persian **mādar**.

Then notice what Urdu did with the Persian one. It took it. *mādar* lives in Urdu too, alongside *māñ* — the borrowed word kept for formal, poetic and respectful use, the inherited word used at home. This is the pairing you already saw when inherited *bhāī* sat beside borrowed *khāndān*: Urdu rarely replaces a native word with a Persian one. It keeps both and gives them different rooms to stand in.

***méh₂tēr** also earns a caution. Words for mother across the world's languages tend to start with *m*, because *ma* is close to the first sound a baby makes, and that resemblance can arise anywhere without any shared ancestor. The Urdu-to-English link here is not that kind of accident — it is traceable step by step through Sanskrit and Proto-Indo-European. But a resemblance to a *mama* in an unrelated family would be.

Your turn

- Say it: **māñ** — mother; then **merī māñ**
- Read it: ہے۔ ماں میری یہ — name the letters of each word, then say it
- Say it: the family words so far — **māñ**, **bahan**, **bhāī**, **dost**, **khāndān**

- *Trace it:* **māñ** ← Sanskrit *mātā* ← PIE **méh₂tēr* → English **mother**, Persian **mādar**
- *Say it:* which of *māñ* and *mādar* you would use at home

Before you move on

Say “this is my mother.” (**yih merī māñ hai.**) Why *merī* and not *merā*? (ماں is **feminine**.) Name the English cousin of ماں. (**Mother**.)
Sources: Wiktionary: ماں.

17.6 ہے — the smallest word, in every sentence you own

Write ہے. Two letters: the small loop, then the wide flat sweep.
Say it: **hai**.

The letters in this word

Four sentences. Read each from the right, word by word, and say it before you move on.

ہے۔ ... نام میرا

ہے۔ ماں میری یہ

ہے۔ کام یہ

ہے۔ کالا یہ

merā nām ... hai. — *yih merī māñ hai.* — *yih kām hai.* — *yih kālā hai.*

Look at what sits at the end of every one of them. ہے is where an Urdu sentence lands, in the place English puts *is* in the middle. You have been producing that landing by ear since the very first sentence you learned; from today you can also see it.

Your turn — by ear

Page shut. Point at things around you and land each sentence on *hai*.

- *Say it: yih kām hai* — this is work
- *Say it: yih merī māñ hai* — this is my mother
- *Say it: yih lāl hai*, then *yih kālā hai*
- *Say it: kahāñ?* — and hum the nasal at its end
- *Listen: to hai, haiñ, hūñ* one after another, and say which is yours when you speak about yourself

Your turn

- *Write it: ہے-کام یہ* — three words, right to left
- *Write it: ے* on its own, ten times, until the flat tail stops curling up
- *Say it:* which of *māñ* and *mādar* is inherited, and which is borrowed
- *Say it:* which of *kām* and English *karma* was worn short, and why

Before you move on

Write “this is work.” (ہے-کام یہ) Which two letters make ے? (ہ and ے.) Which of them can end a word and nothing else? (ے.)

17.7 Practice — ten letters, and a sentence that comes off the page

Write the three letters this chapter has been cashing in, and name each one: ہ، ے، ں. You learned all three in chapters five and six.

The letters in this word

Nothing new is taught here. Read each word from the right, naming its letters before you say it:

یہ
 کام
 ماں
 کہاں
 میں
 ہیں
 نہیں
 ہے

Then the sentences:

ہے۔ ... نام میرا
 ہے۔ ماں میری یہ
 ہے۔ کام یہ
 ہے۔ نہیں کام میرا یہ نہیں،

merā nām ... hai. — yih merī mān hai. — yih kām hai. — nahīn, yih merā kām nahīn hai.

That last one is the first thing in this book you can read that argues back.

What you've built this chapter

Three letters, and three ideas that will keep paying:

- **a letter can change face by position** — gol he standing as one loop and sitting in the middle of a word as two, which is the shape most likely to make a reader think a stranger has arrived
- **a letter can belong to one position only** — big ye and nūn ghunna both close a word and turn up nowhere else, so neither

costs you a middle form

- **a letter can be defined by subtraction** — nūn ghunna is nūn with its dot removed, and the removal is what the letter means

And one arithmetic worth doing out loud. Seven letters gave you eight words. Three more gave you ہے, and with it every sentence you already knew how to end.

Your turn

Page covered. Someone says the word, or you say it to yourself from the romanization alone — then write it in Urdu without looking at a model, and only then compare.

Write these out:

- hear *hai*, write ہے, compare
- hear *maini*, write میں, compare
- hear *nahīn*, write نہیں, compare
- hear *yih merī mān hai*, write it whole, compare and repair

Before you move on

How many letters can you now write? (**Ten.**) Which English word is کام's borrowed twin? (**Karma.**) Which English question words share کہاں's inherited consonant? (**The wh- family** — *who, what, when, where.*) Which of ماں and mādar would you say at home? (ماں.)

Chapter 18

The Meeting Comes Off the Page

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) 👁 eyes (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read aam, aasmaan, purana, aap, voh and hun off the page, name a non-joining letter on sight, and write the opening meeting exchange from dictation.

The exchange the book opens with – salam, aap ka naam kya hai, mera naam ... hai, aap kaise hain, main ... hun – is readable and writable end to end for the first time, on letters taught across chapters one to eight.

18.1 آم — “mango,” and the name that did not travel

Write ہے-کام یت and say it. Ten letters are yours.

You’ll want to know first — one word

آم — ām — mango

Two letters. The second is م, which you have written many times. The first looks like the tall stroke you know with a small wave lying across its head, and that wave is doing a real job — it is the next lesson’s whole subject.

آم is masculine.

yih ām hai. — “This is a mango.”

Say that now; you can already write every word in it except the first letter of *ām*, and that letter arrives shortly.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ām is **inherited**: Sanskrit *āmra* became Prakrit *amba* and then Urdu *ām*, the ordinary north Indian name for the fruit for as long as there has been a north Indian name for it.

Now the part worth slowing down for. English calls the fruit **mango**, and a reader who has newly learned *ām* would reasonably guess the two words are relatives. They are not.

mango came by sea. Portuguese traders on the Malabar coast met the fruit under its **Dravidian** name — Tamil and Malayalam *māṅkāy*, “mango fruit” — carried it home as *manga*, and English took it from Portuguese. So the fruit travelled to Europe wearing a southern Indian name while the northern name stayed where it was.

Two unrelated words for one fruit inside one country, and the one that left is not the one you are learning. That is worth holding: a resemblance is evidence of nothing on its own, and here there is not even a resemblance — the relationship people assume is the one that does not exist.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **ām** — mango; then *yih ām hai*
- *Say it*: the food and drink words so far — **ām**, **pānī**, **chāy**, **dūdh**, **roṭī**
- *Trace it*: **ām** ← Prakrit *amba* ← Sanskrit *āmra*
- *Trace it*: English **mango** ← Portuguese *manga* ← Tamil and Malayalam *māṅkāy* — a different road, from a different family
- *Recall*: say *ṭopī*

Before you move on

Say “this is a mango.” (**yih ām hai.**) Which Indian language family gave English its word for the fruit? (**Dravidian** — Tamil and Malayalam.) Which one gave Urdu آم? (**Indo-Aryan**, through Sanskrit.)
Sources: Wiktionary: آم.

18.2 آسمان — “sky,” which used to mean stone

Say “this is a mango.” (*yih ām hai.*) Which family gave English its word for that fruit? (**Dravidian.**)

You’ll want to know first — one word

آسمان — *āsmān* — sky

Six letters, and five of them are already yours: ن, م, س, ا, and the tall stroke that opens it, wearing the same small wave you met on آم. One shape stands between you and reading this word off the page.

آسمان is masculine.

āsmān nīlā hai. — “The sky is blue.”

That sentence reuses a colour you already own and the copula you learned to write back in chapter six.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

آسمان is **borrowed**, from Persian *āsmān* — the same road that brought *khudā*. Inside Iranian it is inherited, running back through Avestan *asman-* to Proto-Indo-Iranian **aśman-* and to Proto-Indo-European ***h₂ékmōn**.

And ***h₂ékmōn** did not mean sky. It meant **stone**.

Follow it sideways and the family is unmistakable: Sanskrit *aśman* “stone,” Greek *ákmōn* “anvil,” Lithuanian *akmuo* “stone.” Through Germanic the standard reconstruction carries the same root into

English as **hammer** — a word that named a stone tool long before anyone made one out of metal. That last step is the mainstream account rather than a settled one; specialists note formal difficulties with it, so hold it as probable rather than proven.

So how does stone become sky? Because the sky was pictured as a **vault of stone** arching overhead, and the word for the material became the word for the thing built of it. When you say *āsmān*, you are calling the sky a stone in a language that stopped noticing centuries ago.

Set that beside آم from the lesson before. There, a resemblance people expect turns out to be nothing. Here, a resemblance nobody would expect — *āsmān* and *hammer* — is probably real, on evidence rather than on sound. Neither one can be settled by how the words sound. Only the trail settles it, and sometimes the trail answers “probably” rather than “yes”.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **āsmān** — sky; then *āsmān nīlā hai*
- *Say it:* the weather words so far — **āsmān, bārish, dhūp, hawā, garmī, sardī**
- *Trace it:* **āsmān** ← Persian ← Avestan *asman-* ← PIE **h₂ékmon* “stone” → English **hammer**
- *Say it:* which of آم and آسمان has a real English cousin, and which has one people wrongly assume

Before you move on

Say “the sky is blue.” (**āsmān nīlā hai.**) Was آسمان inherited or borrowed into Urdu? (**Borrowed**, from Persian.) Name its English cousin. (**Hammer.**)

Sources: Wiktionary: آسمان.

18.3 پرانا — “old,” and the word behind the Purāṇas

Write آسمان. Two alifs, one wearing the wave and one not — say which is which as you draw them.

You’ll want to know first — one word

پرانا — *purānā* — old

Five letters, and four are yours already: پ, ر, ا, ن. The one that opens it is new to your hand, and it is the next lesson.

پرانا changes its ending to agree with the noun it describes, the way کالا *kālā* and نیلا *nīlā* do:

- پرانا *purānā* with a masculine noun
- پرانی *purānī* with a feminine one

yih kām purānā hai. — “This work is old.”

merī qamīz purānī hai. — “My shirt is old.”

Say each, and notice you are choosing the ending by the noun’s gender without being told which to use — you have made that choice for two chapters of colours already.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

پرانا is **inherited**: Sanskrit *purāṇa*, “ancient, belonging to former times,” built on *purā*, “formerly.” Behind that stands Proto-Indo-European ***per-**, in the sense “forward, before.” That root went everywhere. Greek *pró*, Latin *pro* and *prior*, and in English a whole quiet family: **fore**, **former**, **first**, **before**. Each of them is a way of saying “in front” that turned into a way of saying “earlier” — and پرانا made the same turn, in the same direction, in a different branch.

One more thing this word names. The Sanskrit texts called the **Purāṇas** are this very word, plural: literally “the old ones,” a body of writing whose title is an adjective. When you say *purānā* you are using

the everyday form of a word that also names a library.

Beside $\tilde{A}$, this is the other kind of result. There, a link people expect turns out not to exist. Here, a link nobody expects — *purānā* and English *first* — turns out to hold, all the way down.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **purānā**, then **purānī**, and say what decides the ending
- *Say it:* *yih kām purānā hai*, then *merī gamīz purānī hai*
- *Say it:* the agreeing words you now have — **kālā**, **nīlā**, **purānā**
- *Trace it:* **purānā** ← Sanskrit *purāṇa* ← *purā* ← PIE **per-* → English **fore**, **former**, **first**, **before**

Before you move on

Say “this work is old.” (*yih kām purānā hai*.) What does the name of the Purāṇas mean? (**The old ones.**) Name two English cousins of $\tilde{A}$. (**Fore, former, first, before** — any two.)
Sources: Wiktionary: $\tilde{A}$.

18.4 Eleven letters, and two kinds of answer

Write $\tilde{A}$, then $\tilde{I}$. Say what the wave does and where in a word it belongs. (**Long ā**; at the **start**.)

The letters in this word

Read from the right, naming letters before saying each word:

आ

आस्मान

आना

मा

نہیں

And two sentences, whole:

ہے۔ نیلا آسمان

ہے۔ آم یہ

āsmān nīlā hai. — yih ām hai.

Count what that took. Ten letters carried you to *hai*; one more carried you to the sky.

Your turn

Cover the page. Look, hide, write, uncover, repair.

- Write it: آم — look, cover, write, uncover, repair
- Write it: آسمان — look, cover, write, uncover, repair
- Write it: ہے۔ نیلا آسمان — the whole sentence, then compare
- Say it: *purānā*, and name the one letter in it your hand cannot yet make

Your turn — by ear

Page shut. Three words, three etymologies, and two different verdicts — say which is which out loud.

- Say it: **ām** and English *mango* — related, or only assumed to be?
- Say it: **āsmān** and English *hammer* — related, or only assumed to be?
- Say it: **purānā** and English *first* — related, or only assumed to be?
- Say it: *yih ām purānā hai*, then *merī qamīz purānī hai*
- Listen: for the long ā opening *ām*, *āsmān* and *ānā*, and hold it

The point of putting those three together is that **the sound tells you nothing**. *ām* and *mango* look like a match and are not one. *āsmān* and *hammer* look like nothing at all and are probably cousins. Only the trail decides, and it is allowed to answer “probably”.

Before you move on

How many letters can you write? (**Eleven.**) Write “the sky is blue.”
(ہے۔ نیلا آسمان) Which word in this lesson is still waiting on a
letter? (*purānā.*)

18.5 وہ — “that,” and everyone who is not here

Write آپ. Say where pe’s three dots sit, and who you would
address as *āp*.

You’ll want to know first — one word

وہ — *voh* — **that**; and **he, she, they**

Two letters. The second is **ہ**, closing the word with its round curl. The
first is **و**, which you learned to write in chapter eight.

وہ is the far partner of یہ. One points at what is beside you; the other
points at what is over there:

yih ām hai. — “This is a mango.” (in your hand)

voh ām hai. — “That is a mango.” (on the tree)

And then it does a second job that English splits across four words. The
thing over there does not have to be a thing:

voh merī mān haiñ. — “She is my mother.”

Urdu names the person you are talking **about** with the same word it
uses for the thing you are pointing **at**. Notice the copula in that sentence:
haiñ, not *hai*, because a mother is spoken of with respect, exactly as you
already do when you address someone as *āp*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

یہ and وہ did not arrive separately. They come down together from the
Old Indo-Aryan demonstratives Sanskrit wrote as *iyam* — the near
one — and *asau* — the far one. Urdu inherited a **pair**, and it still runs
the pair the way it inherited it: everything Urdu points at gets sorted

into near or far first, and only then into what it actually is. English does the same sorting with **this** and **that**, and once did it with a third, **yon**, now almost gone. But English uses separate words for the people it talks about — *he, she, they*. Urdu keeps the far pointer doing both jobs, which is fewer words to learn and one more reason context does the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **voh** — that; and point at something across the room
- *yih ām hai*, then *voh ām hai*, pointing differently each time
- *voh merī mān hai* — and say why the copula is *hai*
- the three pointing and person words you now own — **main**, **yih**, **voh**

Before you move on

Which is nearer, **ye** or **wo**? (**ye**.) Say “that is a mango.” (**voh ām hai**.) Why *hai* when you speak about your mother? (**Respect** — the same reason you say *āp*.)

Sources: Wiktionary: **ye**.

18.6 The opening exchange, read off the page

Write **آ**. The wave on the alif, then the boat with three dots under it.

The letters in this word

Here is the exchange you learned in your first hour of Urdu. Every letter in it is now one your own hand can make. Read each line from the right, naming its words, then say it:

سلام

ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ

ہے۔ ... نام میرا

ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

salām — āp kā nām kyā hai? — merā nām ... hai. — āp kaise haiñ?

Look at the second line. آپ ends with pe wearing its full boat, and ہے and میں are the same gol he under two different endings.

Only the reply *main̄ thīk hūñ* is still out of reach, and by three shapes — one of which arrives next lesson.

Your turn

Cover the page. Look, hide, write, uncover, repair.

Write these out:

- ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ — look, cover, write the whole question, uncover, repair
- ہے۔ ... نام میرا — with your own name in the gap
- ہیں؟ کیسے آپ — and check both endings against the model

Your turn — by ear

Page shut. Run the whole meeting aloud with an imagined stranger, then a friend.

Say these aloud:

- *salām — āp kā nām kyā hai?* — and answer as yourself
- *āp kaise haiñ?* to a man, then *āp kaisī haiñ?* to a woman
- *yih ām hai*, then *voh ām hai*, and point differently

Before you move on

Read the question aloud from the page. (ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ) Which reply can you still not write? (*main thīk hūn.*) How many letters do you now have? (Twelve.)

18.7 Practice — thirteen letters, and the meeting comes off the page

Write the three letters this chapter has been cashing in, and name each: آ، پ، و. You learned all three in chapters seven and eight.

The letters in this word

Nothing new is taught here. Read each word from the right, naming its letters first:

آم

آسمان

پرانا

پانی

آپ

وہ

ہوں

کون

Then the whole meeting, whole:

سلام

ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ

ہے۔ ... نام میرا

ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

ہوں۔ ... میں

ہوں۔ رہا کر کام میں نہیں،

The last line is beyond what you can say yet, and it is there on purpose: every shape in it is one you can name, even where the grammar is still ahead of you. Reading has overtaken speaking for the first time.

What you've built this chapter

Three letters, and three ideas worth more than the letters:

- **a mark can be shorthand for a repetition** — alif madda is two alifs collapsed into one, so it opens a word and appears nowhere else
- **dots outlive shapes** — pe's boat shrinks to a tooth when it joins, its three dots stay, and on a crowded page you count dots rather than hunt curves
- **non-joiners come in a family** — with vā'o beside alif, the gaps inside Urdu words stop being surprises

And the chapter's real argument: پ exists because Arabic has no p and Persian built the letter Urdu now uses. The alphabet was borrowed and then altered, and the alterations are visible if you count dots.

Your turn

Page covered. Hear the word — or say it to yourself from the romanization — then write it in Urdu with no model in front of you, and only then compare.

Write these out:

- hear *āp*, write آپ, compare
- hear *hūn*, write ہوں, compare
- hear *voḥ ām hai*, write it whole, compare and repair
- hear *āp kā nām kyā hai?*, write it whole, compare and repair

Before you move on

How many letters can you now write? (**Thirteen.**) Which of آم/*mango* and آسمان/*hammer* is a real cousin pair? (آسمان and *hammer*.) Why does پ carry three dots? (**Persian invented it** for a sound Arabic lacks.)

Pronunciation & Script Reference

A **reference**, not a chapter. Use it when a lesson names a sound; do not clear it as an alphabet gate. Urdu script is introduced through useful expressions, with only the shapes and sound contrasts needed on that page.

The track shows a learner romanization beside new Urdu. A line above a vowel marks length ($\bar{a}$, $\bar{i}$), and a tilde marks nasalization ($\tilde{a}$, $\tilde{i}$). Cover the romanization once the Urdu form is familiar.

Script, spelling, and type style

- **Read right to left** (rtl). Start each word at its right edge.
- **Letters usually join** and change shape by position. Some letters, including ل and و in current words, break the connection to the following shape on their left.
- Urdu is an **abjad**: some vowels are unwritten and inferred from the learned word (**short-vowels-unwritten**). Long vowels use letter shapes such as ا , و , and ي ; ـ can carry e/ai .
- Urdu is traditionally printed in **Nastaliq**, whose connected words descend in a flowing slope. The book and app use the vendored static Noto Nastaliq Urdu family, including its Urdu OpenType localization and contextual joins. Naskh remains an accessibility fallback when a learner's browser cannot load the course font; it is no longer the normal presentation.

Sound ids used by the starter lessons

- **Sound id: rtl**
What to do: follow the word from its right edge leftward
First anchor: سلام *salām*
- **Sound id: long-a**
What to do: hold *ā* steady; / carries it in سلام
First anchor: سلام *salām*
- **Sound id: alif-madd**
What to do: read ا as word-initial long *ā*
First anchor: آپ *āp*
- **Sound id: short-vowels-unwritten**
What to do: supply the learned short vowels even when vowel marks are absent
First anchor: شکریہ *shukriyā*
- **Sound id: long-i**
What to do: hold ی as *ī* in this word
First anchor: جی *jī*
- **Sound id: long-u**
What to do: hold و as long *ū* in the learned word
First anchor: ہوں *hūn*
- **Sound id: nasal-vowel**
What to do: let air pass through the nose; final ں does not add a full English *n*
First anchor: ہاں *hā*, نہیں *nahī*
- **Sound id: long-vowels**
What to do: read the word's written long-vowel cues rather than stretching every vowel
First anchor: نام میرا *merā nām*
- **Sound id: hai-diphthong**
What to do: say ہے as one *hai* syllable, ending in an *ai* glide
First anchor: ہے *hai*

- **Sound id: sh**
What to do: read three-dotted ش as *sh*
First anchor: شکریہ *shukriyā*
- **Sound id: kh**
What to do: make خ farther back than English *h*
First anchor: خوشی *khushī*
- **Sound id: consonantal-ye**
What to do: let ی supply consonantal *y* before a vowel
First anchor: کیا *kyā*
- **Sound id: ai-diphthong**
What to do: say *ai* as one glide in the learned question word
First anchor: کیسے *kaise*
- **Sound id: final-ye**
What to do: distinguish broad final ے *e* from final ی long *ī*
First anchor: کیسے / کیسی *kaise / kaisī*
- **Sound id: retroflex-aspirated-th**
What to do: curl the tongue slightly back for ٹ, then release the aspiration marked by ہ
First anchor: ٹھیک *ṭhīk*
- **Sound id: urdu-question-mark**
What to do: recognize ؟ at the left end of a right-to-left question
First anchor: ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ
- **Sound id: be-vs-pe-dots**
What to do: count the dots under the shared low scoop: one below is ب *b*, three below are پ *p*
First anchor: بولنا *bolnā* against آپ *āp*
- **Sound id: geminate-nun**
What to do: hold the *n* long when two ن letters are written in a row
First anchor: جانتا *jānnā*

- **Sound id: che-vs-jim-dots**
What to do: count the dots below the *jīm* body: one is چ *j*, three are چ *ch*
First anchor: سوچنا *sochnā* against جانا *jānā*
- **Sound id: do-chashmi-he**
What to do: give ہ no sound of its own; let it aspirate the letter to its right
First anchor: سمجھنا *samajhnā*, لکھنا *likhnā*
- **Sound id: retroflex-flap-rre**
What to do: flick a curled-back tongue once for ڑ; do not roll it
First anchor: پڑھنا *parhnā*
- **Sound id: majhul-e**
What to do: read medial ی as long *e* where the learned word calls for it
First anchor: لینا *lenā*
- **Sound id: qaf-uvular**
What to do: draw the back of the tongue further back in the throat for ق than for ک; many speakers merge the two in casual speech
First anchor: قیض *qamīz*
- **Sound id: te-dots-vs-tte-loop**
What to do: two dots above make plain dental ت; a small raised loop instead makes retroflex ٹ
First anchor: جوتا *jūtā* against ٹھیک *ṭhīk*
- **Sound id: gaf-stroke**
What to do: گ is ک with one extra stroke laid across the top
First anchor: گرمی *garmī*

Shape families already in use

- س *s* and ش *sh* share a skeleton; three dots distinguish ش.
- ن is consonantal *n*. Final dotless ں is *nūn-e ghunna* and marks nasalization in ہاں and نہیں.

- ی supplies the long $\bar{y}$ in جی and نہیں. Final ے participates in *hai* in ہے. Learn each role in its word before generalizing.
- کیا gives ی its consonantal y job; کیسی / کیسے then contrast broad final ے with long- $\bar{y}$ final ی.
- ٹھیک introduces the Indic retroflex-plus-aspiration sequence ٹھ only when the wellbeing reply needs it.
- حافظ خدا reuses خ and long l , adds a clear initial h in حافظ, and reads final ظ as z . Urdu conventionally keeps the two words visibly spaced, even though Persian normally joins its local spelling.
- بولنا adds the only new consonant the verb chapter needs: ب b , one low scoop with a single dot below. It shares that skeleton with پ p , already read in آپ, which carries three dots below instead. Dot count is the whole difference, and it is load-bearing throughout the alphabet.
- جانا writes two ن letters in a row and pronounces both, which is the only thing separating it from جانا $jānā$. Nothing about the doubling is decorative: جانا is “to go” and جانتا is “to know.”
- چ ch is the ج j body with **three dots below** instead of one — the same dot-count contrast as ب against پ, on a second skeleton.
- ھ is *do-chashmī* he , “two-eyed he.” It is never a consonant on its own; it aspirates whatever letter stands to its right. ٹھیک used it first, and سمجھنا, پڑھنا, پوچھنا and لکھنا use it again in جھ, ڑھ, چھ and کھ. Keep it apart from round ھ *gol* he , which is a real h and is the letter in ہوں and ہونا.
- ر is ر r wearing the small retroflex mark that also rides on ٹ. One diacritic, one instruction — curl the tongue back — now on two letters.
- ی takes a **third** value in لینا $lenā$: a long e . With consonantal y in کیا and long $\bar{y}$ in جی, and broad final ے beside it, the *ye* family covers y , $\bar{y}$ and e ; the learned word decides.

- **ق** *qāf*, first read in **قیض**, shares its throat position with already-known **خ** but is a stop rather than a fricative — a plosive version of the same back-of-the-mouth place. **ض** *zād*, in the same word, joins **ظ** (from **حافظ**) as a second letter carrying the plain **z** sound in Urdu, even though Arabic once told the two apart.
- **ت** *te*, first read in **جوتا**, shares its base scoop with already-known **ٹ**: two dots above make it plain dental *t*, where a small raised loop instead makes **ٹ** retroflex.
- **گ** *gāf*, first read in **گرمی**, is already-known **ک** with one extra stroke laid across the top — the same dot-count logic that told **ب** apart from **پ**, this time with a stroke instead of a dot.

The Persian-Arabic and Indo-Aryan layers

Script does not determine a word's history. **شکریہ** and **سلام** expose the Persian-Arabic literary layer; **نہیں**, **میرا**, **نام**, and **ہے** expose the inherited Indo-Aryan core that Urdu shares with Hindi. Mixed-language practice may use that relationship as a bridge, but the Urdu script remains the assessed form for this track.

Sources

- *Zero Zabar*: How the Urdu script works
- *Zero Zabar*: The Urdu alphabet

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

آم *ām*

mango — the inherited Indo-Aryan name for the fruit, and not the ancestor of English mango
Introduced in Chapter 18.

آنا *ānā*

to come — literally “go toward,” built from a prefix and the verb for going
Introduced in Chapter 6.

آنکھ *ānikh*

eye — a fifth base letter for the two-eyed he, and another real cousin of an English word
Introduced in Chapter 10.

آپ / تم / تو *āp / tum / tū*

you — respectful / familiar / intimate
Introduced in Chapter 3.

آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ *āp kā nām kyā hai?*

What is your name? (respectful)
Introduced in Chapter 3.

آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ ہیں؟ کیسے آپ *āp kaise haiṅ? / āp kaisī haiṅ?*

How are you? — respectfully to a man / woman
Introduced in Chapter 4.

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی *āp se mil kar khushī huī*

pleased to meet you
Introduced in Chapter 3.

آسمان *āsmān*

sky — Persian, from a root that meant stone, and a cousin of the English word hammer
Introduced in Chapter 18.

بہن *bahan*

sister — feminine, where بھائی was masculine, and the reason میرا has to change shape
Introduced in Chapter 9.

بارش *bārish*

rain — Persian, built from “load” plus a noun-forming ending, and a dead end behind that
Introduced in Chapter 15.

بھائی *bhāī*

brother — the first noun this book has taught with a real grammatical gender, and a genuine English cousin
Introduced in Chapter 9.

بولنا *bolnā*

to speak — the plain Indo-Aryan verb under Urdu’s Persian and Arabic finery
Introduced in Chapter 6.

چائے *chāy*

tea — Persian again, this time by an overland road from Chinese, and the hamza-ye letter’s second word
Introduced in Chapter 12.

دھوپ *dhūp*

sunshine — inherited, and another honest dead end, like کان and روٹی before it
Introduced in Chapter 15.

دل *dil*

heart — Persian, and a real cousin of English heart by the Iranian road, not the Sanskrit one
Introduced in Chapter 11.

دوست *dost*

friend — a Persian word that refuses to pick a gender, and exactly the relationship تم was made for
Introduced in Chapter 9.

دودھ *dūdh*

milk — a sixth letter learns to breathe, and an English cousin that is NOT the word you’d guess
Introduced in Chapter 12.

گرمی *garmī*

heat — Persian, from the same PIE root as Greek thermós, with English warm only a disputed distant cousin
Introduced in Chapter 15.

حافظ *hāfiz*

guardian, protector — the Arabic-rooted half of the farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

ہوا *hawā*

air, wind — Persian, and Persian’s own loan from Arabic, a loan of a loan rather than two roads from one root
Introduced in Chapter 15.

ہونا *honā*

to be — and the ending every Urdu verb wears when you name it
Introduced in Chapter 6.

جانا *jānā*

to go — the verb that shows the two agreements an Urdu present tense makes at once
Introduced in Chapter 6.

جاننا *jānnā*

to know — the Urdu cousin of English know, Latin notice, and Greek gnosis
Introduced in Chapter 6.

ہاں جی *jī hā*

yes
Introduced in Chapter 1.

جوتا *jūtā*

shoe — inherited, and a real cousin of English yoke, and of Sanskrit’s own yoga
Introduced in Chapter 14.

کہاں *kahāñ*

where — the fourth member of Urdu’s k- question family, and a cousin of English where by way of PIE *k^wis*
Introduced in Chapter 17.

کیسی / کیسے *kaise / kaisī*

how — addressing a man / addressing a woman
Introduced in Chapter 4.

کالا *kālā*

black — inherited, but from a root borrowed into Sanskrit itself, and the first color that changes its own ending
Introduced in Chapter 13.

کام *kām*

work — inherited from Sanskrit karman, whose borrowed twin English spells karma
Introduced in Chapter 17.

کان *kān*

ear — the first body word since Chapter 4 folded آپ کیسے ہیں؟ into a single wellbeing check
Introduced in Chapter 10.

خاندان *khāndān*

family — the collective word this chapter's three people-words never needed, and Persian, like every social word Urdu has borrowed so far
Introduced in Chapter 9.

خدا *khudā*

God — the Persian-borrowed half of the standard Urdu farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

خدا حافظ *khudā hāfiz*

goodbye — a standard Urdu farewell
Introduced in Chapter 5.

کوٹ *koṭ*

coat — a modern English loan, closing a chapter that showed loans running in both directions
Introduced in Chapter 14.

کیا *kyā*

what
Introduced in Chapter 3.

لال *lāl*

red — Persian, and an adjective that never changes its ending
Introduced in Chapter 13.

لینا *lenā*

to take — a verb worn down to one syllable, and the third job Urdu gives the letter ی
Introduced in Chapter 8.

لکھنا *likhnā*

to write — an inherited verb for an act whose every tool Urdu named in Arabic and Persian
Introduced in Chapter 7.

کرنا مدد *madad karnā*

to help — an Arabic noun plus a native verb, which is the machine Urdu used to swallow two foreign vocabularies whole
Introduced in Chapter 8.

میں ... ہوں *main ... hūn*

I am ...

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ٹھیک میں شکریہ ہوں، *main ṭhik hūn, shukriyā*

I am fine, thank you

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ماں *mān*

mother — inherited from Sanskrit *mātā*, cousin of English mother, and neighbour of borrowed Persian *mādar*

Introduced in Chapter 17.

ہے ... نام میرا *merā nām ... hai*

my name is ...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

منہ *munh*

mouth — the plain *نون* that already nasalized *آنکھ*, unglossed, and a Greek word possibly hiding behind the same root

Introduced in Chapter 10.

نہیں *nahī*

no / not

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ناک *nāk*

nose — the same three letters as *کان*, read in reverse, and a real cousin of the English word this time

Introduced in Chapter 10.

نیلا *nīlā*

blue — an honest dead end backward, and the word behind English aniline going forward

Introduced in Chapter 13.

پانی *pānī*

water — the first word you would actually ask for, and a verb from three chapters ago put back to work

Introduced in Chapter 12.

پڑھنا *paṛhnā*

to read — and to study, and to recite, because it never meant reading silently
Introduced in Chapter 7.

پسند *pasand*

liked, pleasing — a Persian word, not a verb, in the one Urdu sentence that
refuses to let you be its subject
Introduced in Chapter 8.

پوچھنا *pūchhnā*

to ask — and the one place where Urdu’s inherited half and its Persian half turn
out to be the same word
Introduced in Chapter 8.

پرانا *purānā*

old — inherited from Sanskrit purāṇa “belonging to former times,” and a cousin
of English fore and first
Introduced in Chapter 18.

قمیض *qamīz*

shirt — Arabic, and probably the very same word English borrowed as chemise,
by a completely different road
Introduced in Chapter 14.

روٹی *roṭī*

bread — an honest dead end, and پسند put back to work on everything this
chapter taught
Introduced in Chapter 12.

سفید *safed*

white — Persian, and a real cousin of English white by the Iranian road, the same
shape as دل and hṛdaya
Introduced in Chapter 13.

سلام *salām*

hello / peace
Introduced in Chapter 1.

سمجھنا *samajhnā*

to understand — literally to wake up fully, on the root that named the Buddha
Introduced in Chapter 7.

سردی *sardī*

cold — Persian, garmī’s opposite, and a hook back through this whole book’s
two-roads words
Introduced in Chapter 15.

شکریہ *shukriyā*

thank you

Introduced in Chapter 1.

سوچنا *sochnā*

to think — a verb that began as a word for burning and grieving

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ٹھیک *ṭhīk*

fine, well, correct

Introduced in Chapter 4.

ٹوپی *ṭopī*

cap, hat — an honest dead end backward, and the word English borrowed as

topee going forward

Introduced in Chapter 14.

وہ *voh*

that, and he, she, they — the far partner of yih, inherited from the same Old

Indo-Aryan pair

Introduced in Chapter 18.

یہ *yih*

this — the nearer of Urdu's two pointing words, and a word whose second letter
you cannot yet write

Introduced in Chapter 17.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 س — *three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting*
How many times do you lift the pen while writing s̄in?

Chapter 2

2.1 ہے ... نام میرا — *my name is ...*
Type the Urdu sentence 'My name is Sara.'

2.2 | — *one stroke, and a page that runs the other way*
Besides running right to left, what else does an Urdu word do as it moves across the page?

Chapter 3

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — *three relationships inside "you"*
Type the Urdu 'you' safest in a first meeting.

3.2 کیا — *what*
Type Urdu for 'what'.

3.3 ل — *alif, and then a bowl under the line*
Does the bowl of lām sit on the baseline or below it?

3.4 آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *ask a name respectfully*

Type the respectful Urdu question 'What is your name?'

3.5 ہوئی خوشی کر مل سے آپ — *pleased to meet you*

Type the Urdu response 'Pleased to meet you.'

3.6 م — *a round head, and a tail under the line*

When mīm is joined into the middle of a word, which part of it survives?

3.7 Practice — *a complete Urdu name exchange*

After someone asks آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟, type the Urdu answer using Sara.

Chapter 4

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — *“how” follows the addressee*

Type the Urdu 'how' form used when respectfully addressing a woman.

4.2 Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

You see a gap in the middle of an Urdu word. What is the likeliest reason?

4.3 آپ کیسی ہیں؟ / آپ کیسے ہیں؟ — *ask respectfully*

Type the respectful Urdu question 'How are you?' addressed to a man.

4.4 میں ... ہوں — *one frame for “I am ...”*

Type the Urdu frame 'I am ...', leaving three dots for the state word.

4.5 ک — *a bowl with a slash laid over it*

How many times do you lift the pen when writing kāf?

4.6 ٹھیک — *“fine,” “well,” and “correct”*

Type the Urdu word meaning 'fine' or 'well'.

4.7 شکر یہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — *“I am fine, thank you”*

Reply in Urdu: 'I am fine, thank you.'

4.8 ن — *a deep bowl, and one dot*

Where does the dot of nūn sit — above the bowl or low inside it?

4.9 Practice — *an Urdu wellbeing exchange*

After آپ کیسے ہیں؟, type the polite Urdu reply.

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — *the first half of an Urdu farewell*

Type the Urdu word khudā, meaning 'God'.

5.2 ی — *one S-curve, no dots*

How many dots does the standalone ye carry?

5.3 حافظ — *“guardian” or “protector”*

Type the Urdu word hāfiz, meaning 'guardian' or 'protector'.

5.4 حافظ خدا — *goodbye*

Type the standard Urdu expression for 'goodbye'.

5.5 ہ — *the round he, and its four faces*

What does gol he look like in the MIDDLE of a word?

5.6 Practice — *open, check, and close*

The short Urdu interaction is ending. Type the final expression.

Chapter 6

6.1 ں — *nūn with the dot taken off*

What is the difference between ں and ن?

6.2 ے — *the big ye, and the end of the sentence*

Where in a word does baṛī ye appear?

Chapter 7

7.1 آ — *alif, with a wave on its head*

Where in a word do you write آ rather than plain ا for a long ā?

7.2 پ — *three dots under a boat*

When pe shrinks to a tooth at the start of a word, what stays the same?

7.3 لکھنا — *“to write,” with nothing new left to decode*

Type the Urdu verb meaning 'to write'.

Chapter 8

8.1 و — *a head, a tail, and no hand to the left*

Which two letters so far refuse to join to the letter on their left?

8.2 پسند — *Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu*

Type the Urdu word for 'to me' — the form main takes when it cannot be the subject.

Chapter 9

9.1 بہن — *“sister,” and the word that makes میرا move*

Type the Urdu for 'my sister', choosing the correct form of my.

9.2 خاندان — *“family,” the word your three new nouns never needed*

Type the Urdu word for 'family' — the loan that groups bhāi and bahan together.

Chapter 10

10.1 ناک — *“nose,” the same three letters as کان, backwards*

Type the Urdu word for 'nose' — the same three letters as کان, reversed.

10.2 منہ — *“mouth,” and the نون āṅkh already used without explaining*

Which earlier body word in this chapter also used a plain نون to mark a nasal vowel, unglossed at the time?

Chapter 11

11.1 دل — *“heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word*

Is Urdu دل related to Sanskrit hṛdaya, or is the resemblance a coincidence like پسند and candēre?

Chapter 12

12.1 دودھ — *“milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it*

Which English word is the REAL cousin of دودھ — dough, or doughy?

12.2 روٹی — “bread,” and pasand closes the chapter
Type the Urdu sentence ‘I like bread.’

Chapter 16

16.1 Practice — eight words you already knew, now read
Urdu writes its long vowels but leaves the short ones off the page. What does that mean for a word you have never heard?

Chapter 17

17.1 یہ — “this,” and the letter you are owed
Does یہ point at what is near you or what is far from you?

17.2 کام — “work,” and a word you can read the moment you meet it
Urdu kām and English karma come from one Sanskrit word. Which language inherited it and which borrowed it?

17.3 کہاں — “where,” and the family it belongs to
Urdu question words open with k and English question words open with wh. Are those two marks related?

17.4 Eight letters — read them, hear them, write them back
After you write a covered word from memory, what do you do before moving on?

17.5 ماں — “mother,” and a sentence you can read whole
Urdu keeps both māñ and Persian mādar. Which one is the inherited word?

17.6 ہے — the smallest word, in every sentence you own
Where in an Urdu sentence does ہے sit?

17.7 Practice — ten letters, and a sentence that comes off the page
نہیں opens with a dotted nun and closes with a dotless one. What does each do?

Chapter 18

18.1 آم — “mango,” and the name that did not travel
Is English mango descended from Urdu آم?

18.2 آسمان — “sky,” which used to mean stone

What did the Proto-Indo-European root behind آسمان originally mean?

18.3 پرانا — “old,” and the word behind the *Purāṇas*

You are describing a feminine noun as old. Do you say purānā or purānī?

18.4 Eleven letters, and two kinds of answer

Of ām/mango and āsmān/hammer, which pair is genuinely related?

18.5 وہ — “that,” and everyone who is not here

Besides meaning ‘that’, what else does voh mean?

18.6 The opening exchange, read off the page

In آپ کا نام ہے؟ کیا نام کا آپ pe? which word carries the letter pe?

18.7 Practice — thirteen letters, and the meeting comes off the page

You see a gap inside an Urdu word. Name the two letters you have met that can cause it.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 س — *three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting*

Answer: 0

Also accepted: none; zero; not at all; no lifts; 0 times

Chapter 2

2.1 ہے ... نام میرا — *my name is ...*

Answer: ہے سارا نام میرا

Also accepted: mera naam Sara hai; merā nām Sārā hai

2.2 | — *one stroke, and a page that runs the other way*

Answer: it cascades downward

Also accepted: it goes down; it descends; each letter sits lower; it slopes down to the left; it cascades

Chapter 3

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — *three relationships inside “you”*

Answer: آپ

Also accepted: aap; āp

3.2 کیا — *what*

Answer: کیا

Also accepted: kya; kyā

3.3 ل — *alif, and then a bowl under the line*

Answer: below it

Also accepted: below; below the line; under the baseline; beneath the line

3.4 آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *ask a name respectfully*

Answer: آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟

Also accepted: آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟; aap ka naam kya hai; āp kā nām kyā hai

3.5 آپ سے مل کر مل ہوئی خوشی — *pleased to meet you*

Answer: آپ سے مل کر مل ہوئی خوشی

Also accepted: aap se mil kar khushi hui; āp se mil kar khushī huī

3.6 م — *a round head, and a tail under the line*

Answer: the round head

Also accepted: the head; the round part; the loop; the head, not the tail

3.7 Practice — *a complete Urdu name exchange*

Answer: ہاں سارا نام میرا

Also accepted: mera naam Sara hai; merā nām Sārā hai

Chapter 4

4.1 کیسی / کیسے — *“how” follows the addressee*

Answer: کیسی

Also accepted: kaisi; kaisī

4.2 Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not

Answer: a letter that does not join to the left

Also accepted: a non-joining letter; alif or another non-joiner; a letter that only joins on the right; a letter that refuses to join

4.3 آپ کیسے ہیں؟ / آپ کیسی ہیں؟ — *ask respectfully*

Answer: آپ کیسے ہیں؟

Also accepted: آپ کیسے ہیں؟; aap kaise hain; āp kaise haiñ

4.4 میں ... ہوں — *one frame for “I am ...”*

Answer: میں ... ہوں

Also accepted: میں ... ہوں; main ... hun; main ... hūñ

4.5 ک — *a bowl with a slash laid over it*

Answer: 1

Also accepted: once; one; one lift; 1 time

4.6 ٹھیک — *“fine,” “well,” and “correct”*

Answer: ٹھیک

Also accepted: thik; ṭhik; theek

4.7 شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں — *“I am fine, thank you”*

Answer: شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں

Also accepted: شکریہ ہوں ٹھیک میں; main thik hun shukriya; main ṭhik hūn shukriyā

4.8 ن — *a deep bowl, and one dot*

Answer: low inside it

Also accepted: inside; low inside the bowl; near the baseline; inside the curve; below

4.9 Practice — *an Urdu wellbeing exchange*

Answer: شکریہ ہوں، ٹھیک میں

Also accepted: شکریہ ہوں ٹھیک میں; main thik hun shukriya; main ṭhik hūn shukriyā

Chapter 5

5.1 خدا — *the first half of an Urdu farewell*

Answer: خدا

Also accepted: khuda; khudā; xuda; xudā

5.2 ی — *one S-curve, no dots*

Answer: 0

Also accepted: none; zero; no dots; 0 dots

5.3 حافظ — *“guardian” or “protector”*

Answer: حافظ

Also accepted: hafiz; hāfiz; haafiz; hafez

5.4 حافظ خدا — *goodbye*

Answer: حافظ خدا

Also accepted: khuda hafiz; khudā hāfiz; xuda hafiz; khudahafiz

5.5 ہ — *the round he, and its four faces*

Answer: two small loops side by side

Also accepted: two loops; two small loops; a pair of loops; two little bowls side by side

5.6 Practice — *open, check, and close*

Answer: حافظ خدا

Also accepted: khuda hafiz; khudā hāfiz; khudahafiz

Chapter 6

6.1 ﺝ — *nūn with the dot taken off*

Answer: the dot

Also accepted: one has a dot; ﺝ has no dot; the missing dot; nun ghunna has no dot

6.2 ﻻ — *the big ye, and the end of the sentence*

Answer: at the end

Also accepted: end; word-finally; only at the end; the last letter

Chapter 7

7.1 ﺁ — *alif, with a wave on its head*

Answer: at the start

Also accepted: start; the beginning; word-initially; at the front

7.2 ﺏ — *three dots under a boat*

Answer: the three dots beneath it

Also accepted: the three dots; the dots; three dots below; its dots underneath

7.3 ﻟﻜﻬﻨﺎ — *“to write,” with nothing new left to decode*

Answer: ﻟﻜﻬﻨﺎ

Also accepted: likhna; likhnā; likhnaa

Chapter 8

8.1 و — *a head, a tail, and no hand to the left*

Answer: alif and vao

Also accepted: alif and vāʾo; ʾ and و; alef and vao

8.2 ﻟﯩﺴﻨﺪ — *Urdu does not like things; things please Urdu*

Answer: mujhe

Also accepted: mujhe.; mujhay

Chapter 9

9.1 بہن — *“sister,” and the word that makes میرا move*

Answer: بہن میری

Also accepted: meri bahan; merī bahan

9.2 خاندان — *“family,” the word your three new nouns never needed*

Answer: خاندان

Also accepted: khandan; khāndān

Chapter 10

10.1 ناک — “nose,” the same three letters as کان, backwards

Answer: ناک

Also accepted: naak; nāk

10.2 منہ — “mouth,” and the انہ ānkh already used without explaining

Answer: ānkh

Also accepted: aankh

Chapter 11

11.1 دل — “heart,” Persian, and still a cousin of the English word

Answer: related

Also accepted: related, same root; same PIE root; cousins; yes, related

Chapter 12

12.1 دودھ — “milk,” and a false friend worth naming before you fall for it

Answer: doughty

Also accepted: doughty, not dough

12.2 روٹی — “bread,” and pasand closes the chapter

Answer: mujhe rotī pasand hai

Also accepted: mujhe roti pasand hai

Chapter 16

16.1 Practice — eight words you already knew, now read

Answer: you cannot reliably sound it out

Also accepted: you cannot sound it out; you have to have heard it; you cannot be sure of the vowels; reading and listening must grow together

Chapter 17

17.1 ٰ — “this,” and the letter you are owed

Answer: near

Also accepted: close; nearby; the near one; what is close

17.2 کام — “work,” and a word you can read the moment you meet it

Answer: urdu inherited it, english borrowed it

Also accepted: urdu inherited, english borrowed; urdu inherited it; english borrowed it; urdu by inheritance, english by borrowing

17.3 کہاں — “where,” and the family it belongs to

Answer: yes, both from PIE k^wis

Also accepted: yes; yes, related; same root; both from the same PIE root; yes, from k^wis

17.4 Eight letters — read them, hear them, write them back

Answer: uncover and repair it

Also accepted: compare; compare and repair; uncover and compare; check it against the model; repair it

17.5 ماں — “mother,” and a sentence you can read whole

Answer: maan

Also accepted: mān; maa; the first one; mān is inherited

17.6 ہے — the smallest word, in every sentence you own

Answer: at the end

Also accepted: end; last; the final word; sentence-finally

17.7 Practice — ten letters, and a sentence that comes off the page

Answer: the first is the consonant n, the last is a nasal hum

Also accepted: one is n, one is a hum; first is a consonant, last nasalizes the vowel; dotted is n, dotless is the nasal; the first is n and the second is nasalization

Chapter 18

18.1 آم — “mango,” and the name that did not travel

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, unrelated; no, it is Dravidian; no, from Tamil/Malayalam; not related

18.2 آسمان — “sky,” which used to mean stone

Answer: stone

Also accepted: rock; a stone; stone or rock

18.3 پرانا — “old,” and the word behind the Purāṇas

Answer: purani

Also accepted: purānī; purānī with an i; the i ending

18.4 Eleven letters, and two kinds of answer

Answer: asman and hammer

Also accepted: āsmān and hammer; the second; āsmān/hammer; the sky one

18.5 وہ — “that,” and everyone who is not here

Answer: he, she, they

Also accepted: he; she; they; he/she/they; he or she; the third person

18.6 *The opening exchange, read off the page*

Answer: aap

Also accepted: اَپ; āp; the first word; the word for you

18.7 *Practice — thirteen letters, and the meeting comes off the page*

Answer: alif and vao

Also accepted: alif and vāʾo; ا and ة; alef and vao; alif madda and vao

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. Chapter 4’s wellbeing forms and register contrast, together with Chapter 5’s farewell, follow Michigan State University’s open *Basic Urdu*.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

A

air, wind — Persian, and Persian’s own loan from Arabic, a loan of a loan rather than two roads from one root /هوا/ (hawā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 113

Ask and Answer Names

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 13

B

black — inherited, but from a root borrowed into Sanskrit itself, and the first color that changes its own ending کال (kāla)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 99

blue — an honest dead end backward, and the word behind

English aniline going forward نیلا (nīlā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 99

bread — an honest dead end, and پسند put back to work on

everything this chapter taught روٹی (roṭī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 93

brother — the first noun this book has taught with a real

grammatical gender, and a genuine English cousin بھائی (bhāī)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 73

C

cap, hat — an honest dead end backward, and the word English borrowed as topee going forward ٹوپي (ṭopī)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 105

coat — a modern English loan, closing a chapter that showed

loans running in both directions کوٹ (koṭ)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 14, p. 105

cold — Persian, garmī's opposite, and a hook back through this whole book's two-roads words سردی (sardī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 113

E

ear — the first body word since Chapter 4 folded ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

into a single wellbeing check کان (kān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 10, p. 81

Eight Words, Read Rather Than Recognised

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 121

eye — a fifth base letter for the two-eyed he, and another real

cousin of an English word آنکھ (āṅkh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 81

F

family — the collective word this chapter's three people-words never needed, and Persian, like every social word Urdu has

borrowed so far خاندان (khāndān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 73

fine, well, correct ٹھیک (ṭhīk)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 21

Five Verbs at the Core

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 39

Four Colors

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 99

Four Things You Wear

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 105

Four Verbs Between People

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 63

Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 51

Four Words on the Face

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 81

friend — a Persian word that refuses to pick a gender, and exactly the relationship **دوست** (dost) was made for

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 73

G**Give your name**

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 9

God — the Persian-borrowed half of the standard Urdu**farewell** **خدا** (khudā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

goodbye — a standard Urdu farewell **حافظ خدا** (khudā hāfiz)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 5, p. 31

Greetings and responses

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

guardian, protector — the Arabic-rooted half of the **farewell** **حافظ** (hāfiz)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

H

heart — Persian, and a real cousin of English heart by the Iranian road, not the Sanskrit one **دل** (dil)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 89

heat — Persian, from the same PIE root as Greek thermós, with

English warm only a disputed distant cousin **گرمی** (garmī)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 113

hello / peace **سلام** (salām)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

how — addressing a man / addressing a woman **کیسی** / **کیسے** (kaise / kaisī)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 21

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 21

How are you? — respectfully to a man / woman آپ / ہیں؟ کیسے آپ

کیسی (āp kaise haiñ? / āp kaisī haiñ?)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 21

I

I am ... میں ... ہوں (main ... hūñ)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 21

I am fine, thank you میں ٹھیک ہوں، شکریہ (main ṭhīk hūñ, shukriyā)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 4, p. 21

L

Letters that hold hands, and the one that will not
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 21

liked, pleasing — a Persian word, not a verb, in the one Urdu
sentence that refuses to let you be its subject پسند (pasand)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 63

M

mango — the inherited Indo-Aryan name for the fruit, and not
the ancestor of English mango آم (ām)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 137

milk — a sixth letter learns to breathe, and an English cousin
that is NOT the word you'd guess دودھ (dūdh)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 93

mother — inherited from Sanskrit mātā, cousin of English
mother, and neighbour of borrowed Persian mādar ماں (māñ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 17, p. 125

mouth — the plain نون **that already nasalized** آنکھ, **unglossed, and**
a Greek word possibly hiding behind the same root منہ (muñh)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 81

my name is ... ہے ... نام میرا (merā nām ... hai)
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 9

N

no / not نہیں (nahī)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

nose — the same three letters as کان, read in reverse, and a real

cousin of the English word this time ناک (nāk)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 81

O

old — inherited from Sanskrit purāṇa “belonging to former times,” and a cousin of English fore and first پُرانا (purānā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 137

P

People You’d Introduce

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 73

pleased to meet you آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی (āp se mil kar khushī huī)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

R

rain — Persian, built from “load” plus a noun-forming ending, and a dead end behind that بارش (bārish)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 113

Rain, Sun, Wind, Heat, Cold

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 113

red — Persian, and an adjective that never changes its

ending لال (lāl)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 99

S

shirt — Arabic, and probably the very same word English

borrowed as chemise, by a completely different road قمیض (qamīz)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 105

shoe — inherited, and a real cousin of English yoke, and of

Sanskrit's own yoga جوتا (jūtā)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 105

sister — feminine, where میرا بھائی was masculine, and the reason
has to change shape بہن (bahan)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 73

sky — Persian, from a root that meant stone, and a cousin of the
English word hammer آسمان (āsmān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 137

sunshine — inherited, and another honest dead end, like کان and
روٹی before it دھوپ (dhūp)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 113

T

Take Leave

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 31

tea — Persian again, this time by an overland road from

Chinese, and the hamza-ye letter's second word چائے (chāy)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 93

thank you شکریہ (shukriyā)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

that, and he, she, they — the far partner of yih, inherited from
the same Old Indo-Aryan pair वो (voh)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 137

The Heart

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 89

The Meeting Comes Off the Page

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 137

The Sentence Learns to End

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 125

this — the nearer of Urdu's two pointing words, and a word
whose second letter you cannot yet write یہ (yih)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 17, p. 125

to ask — and the one place where Urdu's inherited half and its
Persian half turn out to be the same word پوچھنا (pūchhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 63

to be — and the ending every Urdu verb wears when you name
it ہونا (honā)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

to come — literally “go toward,” built from a prefix and the verb **for going** آنا (ānā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

to go — the verb that shows the two agreements an Urdu **present tense makes at once** جانا (jānā)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

to help — an Arabic noun plus a native verb, which is the **machine Urdu used to swallow two foreign vocabularies whole** مدد کرنا

(madad karnā)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 63

to know — the Urdu cousin of English know, Latin notice, and Greek gnosis جانا (jānnā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

to read — and to study, and to recite, because it never meant **reading silently** پڑھنا (parhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

to speak — the plain Indo-Aryan verb under Urdu’s Persian and Arabic finery بولنا (bolnā)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

to take — a verb worn down to one syllable, and the third job Urdu gives the letter لينا (lenā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 63

to think — a verb that began as a word for burning and **grieving** سوچنا (sochnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

to understand — literally to wake up fully, on the root that

named the Buddha سمجھنا (samajhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

to write — an inherited verb for an act whose every tool Urdu

named in Arabic and Persian لکھنا (likhnā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

W

Water, Tea, Milk, Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 93

water — the first word you would actually ask for, and a verb **from three chapters ago put back to work** پانی (pānī)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 93

what کیا (kyā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

What is your name? (respectful) آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ (āp kā nām kyā hai?)

explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 13

where — the fourth member of Urdu's k- question family, and a cousin of English where by way of PIE *k^wis* کہاں (kahān)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 17, p. 125

white — Persian, and a real cousin of English white by the Iranian road, the same shape as دل and hṛdaya سفید (safed)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 13, p. 99

work — inherited from Sanskrit karman, whose borrowed twin English spells karma کام (kāṁ)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 17, p. 125

Y

yes ہاں جی (jī hā)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

you — respectful / familiar / intimate آپ / تم / تو (āp / tum / tū)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

Other

آ — **alif, with a wave on its head**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 7, p. 51

ا — **one stroke, and a page that runs the other way**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 9

س — **three teeth, then a bowl, without lifting**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 1, p. 1

رک ش — **three shapes, then stop**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

ل — **alif, and then a bowl under the line**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 13

م — **a round head, and a tail under the line**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 13

ن — **a deep bowl, and one dot**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 21

-  — **a head, a tail, and no hand to the left**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 8, p. 63
-  — **three dots under a boat**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 7, p. 51
-  — **a bowl with a slash laid over it**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 21
-  — **nūn with the dot taken off**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 6, p. 39
-  — **the round he, and its four faces**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 5, p. 31
-  — **one S-curve, no dots**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 5, p. 31
-  — **the big ye, and the end of the sentence**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 6, p. 39